

RISHI VALLEY · PRIVATE REFERENCE · NOT FOR THE PUBLIC SITE

From the group chats — runners-up and keepers for later

Forty-one pieces that didn't make the final cut of the WhatsApp curation, plus one kept only for private reference — drawn from two chat exports, “RVS Alumni” and “RVS Centenary 2026.”

17 July 2026

42 entries · compiled from *docs/content/whatsapp-curation/overflow.md*

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Two entries (marked below) needed their source lines corrected against overflow.md; see the note under each. Entry 42, "A Creative Artist," was cut from the public site at final review and is kept here only for your private reference.

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The Chants in Ojai

Sathya Gourisankar · 1 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

The assembly chants still ring in my ears. When I met Mark Lee sir in 1986 in Ojai first time in US, I remember he played a recording of the chants on his tape recorded and said he often listens to them with tears welling in his eyes! On visits to RV as alum, sitting in on the assembly chants is a must for me like many others, how wonderful they sound in that valley accompanied by the metronomic sounds of the woodpecker outside the auditorium! They are part of the magic of that paradise on earth!

Mark Lee sir, decades after leaving RV, played a recording of the assembly chants in Ojai with tears in his eyes; a beautiful, quotable image of what RV meant to those who taught there.

Coming to Rishi Valley, 1982

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 2 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Since quite a few are writing of the time they joined school, here's my story of the whole affair :))

A long story of how I was plucked out from my cozy kingdom in Coorg to the Neem B house bed next to Chocka.

I did not read much into it , six months earlier , when dad had casually asked me when I got back from my convent school, if I'd like to go to a 'real good school'. I was game. I thought he was referring to the kannada medium school next to ours. I mean, they seemed to be having all the fun, out playing hockey at odd times of the day when no teachers came to take classes for them, while we sat struggling with books and English grammar under the eagle eye of the nuns. To me, that kannada school was definitely a good school !

But it turned out that Dad had a much bigger extravagance planned. A month earlier, he had written to RV (about which he had heard praises from a parent) and RV had called for an interview, and Dad was setting me up nicely. I pretended to be game, attended the interview , humoured Rajesh Dalaal Sir while at it, and then promptly forgot all about it.

And then, it all hit the ceiling, and how! There I was, enjoying my summer holidays at Mom's place in Mangalore, on the 29th of March 1982 (how do I remember this date, let me explain. Its an annual "bhootha kola" for us. Google it. .Suffice to say, a true blue Tulu(Bunt) from Mangalore believes less in Gods and more in this Bhoota or Daiva. And once a year, ritual is held that goes on all night, and at my Mom's, its held on the 29 March of every year. I shall post some pics here so you all can make sense of it. Anyway, the movie Kantara has made this ritual popular now) and we kids were trying to get to sit somewhere safe (a bit wary of the ferociously dressed daiva) when Mom came upto me with a telegram in hand, saying I'd got "a seat". I said no thanks, and that I'd found one myself. Then I saw the telegram in her hand. It was from my Dad from Coorg (he never came for these religious stuff, saying he had better things to do. But its different now. He personally supervises and conducts it now, and insists and makes sure we all are there every year on mar 29 in mangalore) saying I'd been admitted to RV. Now I was less fearful of the daiva and more fearful of this news. Man! I wasnt going to join any boarding school. NO WAY!

Once we got back to Coorg, I went about my business casually, hoping my parents had forgotten this whole business of Rishi Valley. It was only when May22 came close (thats the day every year that my dear old convent re-opened) and there was no sign of the new text and notebooks coming my way, that I realised that I indeed was changing schools.

The days between May 22 and the Jun 12 were like a daze. I had my plan ready. I would refuse to go to RV at the last moment. That way, I would get to bunk an entire month of my good old convent school, was my plan. The day convent re-opened , I saw my friends walk past my house towards school, I was all thrilled and went and chatted them up. But after two- three days, a distance was developing. I could see them form their own new equations and I was only an unavoidable pit-stop (my home was on the way to school).

I kind of, tolerated my convent well. I mean, things were really simple. U did not do your homework, you got caned. Simple. If you argued with a nun, you got caned on your calf. Simple. If you were caught speaking Kannada in school (because we were "Engleeees" medium:)) you were made to kneel down with hands up in the air in front of the class. Simple. If you got your simple additions wrong, a nun's knuckles or a thick book would make contact with your head. Simple. Cause and effect. No complications. We were not emotionally scarred for

life either, because of the violent punishments by the non-violent nuns. No philosophical mumbo jumbo. A bonus being that I had learnt to work the system to my advantage too, slowly but surely floating to the top of the studious eco-system .

But as the D-day neared, and my parents went about buying/getting stitched the humongous amount of clothes mentioned in the admission letter, and the tailor kept mumbling "which bloody school is this" as he went about stitching my pyjama kurtas and my night suits, and after a frantic search, first in the dictionary and then in all kinds of shops for a "hold-all" ,and my Mom started writing to all near and dear and far and not-so-dear ones that her son was to be admitted to the "Worlds best school", I to my dismay, realised this was getting way out of my hands and it was too late to back out now.

Yet, a ray of hope emerged out of nowhere. An aunt wrote back to Mom saying that the date of joining was an inauspicious day. I was thrilled. Surely my God fearing Mom wouldnt send me to RV now. But no, she had Dad write to RV to change the date of admission by a day. And RV being RV, politely refused. The letter said "we do not believe in this . Since it is an admission process, we advice you to bring your son/daughter/ward on the said date , for admission (this was the letter I frantically searched for today but did not find , but I'm sure i will. It will be there somewhere in my almirah in Coorg :))

My mom promptly did the next best thing. She had it all worked out to the last detail. I was to leave home by evening the day previous to the inauspicious day, to my friend's house a few hundred metres away, and spend the night there. The next morning, parents would start from home, pick me up from there, and off we go, straight to RV!

And thats how it went. But not without some drama. At the friends place the night before I left for RV, his parents were so protective of me, they insisted I sleep with them in their room instead of with my friend! Despite my meek protests, thats how it went. I slept with them, so shy that I did not move from the very edge of the bed, in a clinically supine position :)) i dont know what time it was in the dead of the night that I fell, nose first onto the floor, but it was loud enough for my friend's parents to wake up and fuss over me all over again. My embarrassment was well and truly complete. I never slept a wink after that till morning when my parents came, picked me up, and off we drove. To RV. Right past my dear home as I looked on tearfully.

At RV, it was straight to Neemb and straight onto a letter-writing Chocka on my next bed. And then, to the guest house where Priya's parents and mine chattered so much in Tulu that I was lulled into the notion that Tulu was the state language of planet RV.

The next day , I bade goodbye to my parents at the place between the TT room and the Reading room (now its a muruku room I believe). I was wearing my ill fitting white kurta pyjamas as my parents and sis drove off, and then I merged into a sea of Asthachal returned white kurta pyjamas. My dad's words "no uniforms in this new school, to nurture individuality" came to mind :))

I walked into the reading room, and for the first time in my life, read the front page of a newspaper instead of the cartoons that I always went for. After dinner, Chocka found me and we walked back together. He was a fan of the school already and kept telling me "Beautiful place. Lots of trees" and I was thinking "Man ! Whats he talking ?? This is a desert !! I come from Coorg !!!"

That night, in contrast to three nights ago when my Mom was by my side and a low ceiling above, here was a Chockalingam from Madras by my side and a high ceiling with clay tiles and 20 others in the dorm. I made my second plan while staring up. "I will just finish these six years and go back to my old school" 😊😊

Four years later, when I was to leave RV, it was the same thing all over again . The senti me wanted to stay on for a few days after the ICSE exams. I actually wrote to my dad saying so. And he did write to the school . I almost expected a reply "Come on ! You dont want to join on time, you dont want to leave on time"

Good day everyone...

Manisha Arora A charmingly nostalgic read that feels familiar yet wonderfully unique. 🍷

A richly comic full-length essay about being plucked from Coorg to join RV in 1982: the futile astrological delays, the hold-all shopping, and arriving at Neem B thinking “this is a desert.” One of the best-written pieces in the export.

Purandar Is There, Why Worry

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 16 November 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

I once went inside Cave rock, in 7th std. All names mentioned are my classmates.. 1986 ICSE-1988 ISC batch . This was my (pathetic) experience

Ok RV peeps, since I couldnt have a'Nooner'to match Arti's, I did justice to a couple of 'Nighters', and yes, just as I promised, a story :))

Although I really wanted to write more about those report cards that I posted and its after effects, I shall keep that for some other day, since our (oil)man Lilly was in town :))

Lilly ? Thats the thing about RV nicknames. It always stays. Tulu, Lilly, Petty, Puggy, Spannish, Thambi, Holy, Kumbha or the luckier ones whose names were limited to thier initials, GM, MS , KV , TN or the ones known by their shortened names, like Chocka,Gaddu and Maha, or games teachers like Marker,Asga and PK (whose real names I dont know to this day)or seniors like Fanta, Motte, Loyola,(and Onto that Chatura mentioned today too, though I really cant place him)these names have stuck. But when it came to the young ladies, it was always the full names, surnames, and initials if need be 😊 . And hence, Tara.C. Thiagarajan, Vishali.C.Reddy, Pavitha Krishnaswamy, Maya Herzberger etc whose names were taller than their frames :)). Somehow Sivaraman Sivaswamy was an exception, we called him by his full name just to match his frame. Or if Gadela insisted we call him by his name, we would go the other extreme and call him by his full name..Gadela Venkata Ramana Murthy :))

Anyways, in those first few days after we joined RV, when everything is a blur of getting our "kaavaalis and oddhus" right and a hotchpotch of memories, I was told by someone that Lilly,whose admission number was way ahead of mine, almost in single digits😊 , was the one from our class who had lived in RV the longest. He had been there in RV ever since Krishnaji had discovered the Big Banyan tree, was my understanding of the whole situation. But I did feel, however beautiful the flower was, it was an unusual name for a boy :))

And thats why, I almost choked on my food and sprayed it out in a violent cough when told in the DH a few days later that Lilly was the short form of Lilliput. And Purandar was called so because he was...short ! (When he joined RV). Now, this Purandar boy towered over me and a few others like Rajesh Venkatraman and Suresh Kumble. In fact, Rajesh Venkatraman and I had a healthy competition going, to avoid pole position of being the shortest in class. This went on till Ghouse joined school a few months later and destroyed all competition. He was practically half MY size :)) . Ghouse became my benchmark almost immediately, I did not want to grow shorter than him (yes, figure that out. Those were days when I thought one could lose height just as one lost weight 😊) And so, one fine day, I asked Purandar how he managed to put on the height after being a Lilliput. He says "hiking". I ask "where". He says "hills all around" I say "Can U take me ?". He says "Sure. I know every hill around here". I believed him, for he was as old as the hills as far as RV was concerned. "Cave Rock" I told him, for that was a rock that stood imposing over us each time we were on the games field. "This Sunday evening" he said.

And that Sunday evening, Purandar was guide, and I was the hiker as we trudged along the narrow path leading to Cave Rock. Rajesh Venkatraman came along too, for he did not want to miss out on the few inches in height that the hike might endow on us :))

Once we reached Cave Rock was when the madness came over us. We wanted to enter the cave. Purandar says with a Gulliveresque flourish unbecoming of a mere Lilliput "No problem, been there, done that. If we have to enter the cave, we enter from the back, and then exit from the front because that way,its easier inside the cave coz its downhill". Man! This boy knew what he was talking about!

And we followed him to the back of the cave. When I saw the constricted entrance, was when the first wave of self-doubt hit me. But then, so what? Purandar was there. Why worry? We entered. All three of us. And the insides of the cave had all the ingredients that I had imagined. The cold moist mouldy smell, somewhat softish ground..

But the path inside kept getting narrower and narrower. Till we, though short, had to actually crouch to move ahead. And it was getting darker by the minute.

But ..so what. Purandar was there, why worry?. He says "Now here's where it gets tricky. Keep to the right wall" And then, bats. And bat droppings all over. And in the faint light, I could see the first signs of nervousness on Purandar's face with a few #confusedexpressions :))

"Or was it the left wall...." he trailed off. That's it. At that precise moment, panic gripped us. I could smell, along with the smell of bat droppings, a distinct smell of human droppings from Rajesh Venkatraman's direction 🤢🤢.

And it was at that precise moment that I made a promise to myself, never to blindly follow someone with self-certified experience, ESPECIALLY if the experienced one happens to be an 11 yr old :))

But then there was no turning back. There was no room, for one. I don't know how many of you have gone through that cave, but if you have, you'd remember that at places, we have to crawl through. And when we crawled through, we actually saw animal paw-marks, which I hoped were some dog's, even if large, but which Purandar continues to insist, were bear marks.

"So what, purandar is there. , so what, purandar is there" is what I kept saying to myself. Slowly the chant converted into "Purandara vittala, purandara vittala...(no repeat no connection to Surabhi Vittal 😊) till I felt a whiff of fresh air coming at us from the opposite side. And when we saw the faint light through that tunnel at the other end, it was nothing short of Nirvana :))

Three days ago, as Purandar sat on a parapet wall trying to fit my shoes on his feet, I was thinking, the hike worked. At least the feet size matched:))

And when my wife said " Looks like you ordered more beer than usual" I replied, obviously from Random Access Memory, "So what. It's Ok...Purandar is there. Why worry? 😊 .

Good night everyone. Today was Mark's day out. Rekha's son. Adorable kid. Spent the day with us. No hikes and caves for them though. Mark and Prarthan seem happy with Football, Movies, videogames and Pizza :))

A funny, self-contained caving-dare story ("Purandar is there, why worry") that lands a callback punchline decades later as a life mantra.

Arrow in the Dark

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 5 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Well, we played that in the mid-eighties. Am still trying to know which sadist batch started it 😊 . My story on it.....here goes

Arrow in the Dark

We don't associate RV with violence, do we ? RV, from what I remember, was a very quiet place. Asthachal quiet, classrooms quiet(compared to the cacophony i saw later on when I changed school) , even DH quiet (do we all remember the one-minute silence we observed before we started to chomp ?) . In fact, the only collective sound we made was during those chanting sessions in the assembly :))

And of course, during games. And so, its but natural that most of the memories that we have of RV might pertain to the games field. There are games we may never ever have played ever since RV. Kho kho, Dodgeball, Handball, Netball come to mind. And of course, the improvised games like foot baseball (we played that in the kabaddi court. Rules of baseball, but played with a football. Ram was fantastic at it) , French cricket (with a tennis ball and racquet. Hit the ball, and then rotate the racquet around oneself for a run. Maha with his wiry frame was good at that) Connection hockey (where a few of us stood at regular intervals , the whole length of the hockey field. The first person hit, the second one connected to it and so on. The ball would change direction slightly and dart at high speeds after every connection. By the time the ball reached the last-but-one guy, the ball had reached a crazy maddening speed and if the second last guy was GM, he wud swing his hockey stick and manage to give the ball that final thrust above its threshold level and it would be flying a good distance in the air at waist level. Now the last guy had to stop that ball to escape being the last guy the next time round. Or pray that someone missed, in which case the boy who missed would be made to go to the end of the line.

Figure that out. We actually played all this! And of course, mixed throw ball, in which Pavitha Krishnaswamy, with her vicious swerving throws, would demoralise the guys so much, a few of us came up with excuses to not actually play with girls :))

But the game that I then held in high esteem, was one that was talked about in hushed tones among the non-senior boys hostel guysyep, Dark Room.

Dark room, was played only in the senior boys' hostel. So a few of us who , contrary to convention, had to stay on in our Neem houses even in the 9th(b'coz we were puny and not yet 'ready' for senior boys hostel, was the logic I suppose), had to wait till 10th to get to play Dark Room. And when we finally shifted to the senior hostel, within a few days I started to ask around "So when do we get to play dark room?" And was told "Be patient, ye shall be summoned" or something to that effect.

Few days later, after the late Sunday breakfast, when someone did whisper to me conspiratorially "Darkroom. Today 11 am. Get your blanket and counterpane along",I gulped down my Masala dosa and ran to Trishul house, collected by already folded blanket, yanked the counterpane off my mattress and was present at Kailash house well before time. And of course,wanted to know minor details, like the rules of the game. And was told. "C'mon man just play. There are no rules".

Now what was this about ? Anyways I kind of gathered that it was all about everyone getting into a room made dark by shutting out all light using blankets and counterpanes. And then one had to enter into that room and catch and name the person caught. And one could do anything to avoid getting caught.Anything ? Yes anything.

That's the day I realised the devil lay in the details. And when I saw Petty enter the dark room with a freshly wet towel knotted at one end, and swinging it in an arc with water spraying out, as if he was a cowboy about to snare a calf, I realised this whole thing was a bad idea.,

But then, peers. Pressure. I got in. Survival instinct beckoned me almost instantly. And so, in search of safety, i climbed onto that space above the cupboards where our trunks were kept. As i squeezed myself quietly into that space, settled down, and was about to wrap my blanket around myself, I sensed a sudden silence in the room. As I peered down from my perch, (the lights were still on) I saw everyone stare at me inquisitively. And Sanjiv Mohanty asks "So....u plan to jump onto the chap from there?" Everyone giggled. I just shrugged. I wasn't coming down to face that free-for-all, come what may. Everyone then went about their mission, as in rolling bed sheets into slings and whips, shaping blankets into a snare, fluffing pillows to a wallop, nothing short of guerilla warfare. If any RV parent had seen that room then, no chance they'd allow their child to continue at RV :))

And then, lights were off. And the proverbial gloves too. My God, we could make a room real dark! . And then, the bakra entered, and the door quickly closed behind him. Real quiet inside for a few seconds. And then, action. Of the worst kind. I could hear whipping sounds and stings of wet towels, blankets being thrown and then someone lunging and lashing about and calling out name and then pleading "stop hitting. I've already called out the name" It was total horror to me when the lights came on. I looked wide eyed at the heap of guys who had piled on one another and just as they disentangled, everyone agreed that the correct name had been called or whatever. In short, i couldn't make out head or tail of what this game was all about!

And then, repeat. The guy who got caught had to go out and then come back once the room was dark again.

I was scared stiff to even move. So I stayed put on top of the cupboards. Till someone pointed to me that the guy outside already knew I was on top of the cupboards. I quickly climbed down just before the lights went off again, and crouched at the farthest corner I could find. All went quiet again. The chap entered, the door creaked shut and..nothing happened for a while. And just as I was wondering what the hell was happening, a palm. On my head. Caught hold of my hair. Before I could recover from my hair standing on end, he shouted "TULU! This is TULU. And pulled me up by my hair. And then suddenly the room came alive. It felt like the whole of RV was jumping on me. There were boys falling over each other in the tangle of bed sheets and counterpanes and wet towels. There was some whipping and one loud "Ouch".

And then, I only remember starting to fall backwards. Just couldn't balance myself b'coz my legs were hopelessly entangled in the whole mess and the whole bunch were falling along with me as if in slow motion. I couldn't do much except let gravity take its course. The first thing that made contact was the concrete edge of the bed. On my lower back. And then the whole bunch fell on me. I thought I was dying.

The pain on my back was excruciating. Even after each one disentangled himself and the lights came on. I did manage to get up and i heard someone say "Tulu is out". I was thinking he meant "conked out" 😊. I was ushered outside and told to enter after two mins.

I entered. Not the dark room but the common room which was in the opposite direction. And then I made a quick quiet exit and went back to Trishul and lay down on my bed. I really cant remember what happened after that. I know i skipped lunch, and during dinner too, funnily no one brought up the topic of me deserting the game.

My right of passage had been a disaster. And when someone again said to me a few days later "Dark roo....." I cut him off with a firm "No. Way". Maybe that was my true right of passage, saying a firm no to something I did not want. As Arti pointed out a little while earlier. "Say no...and face consequences. Simple" :))

Its been 30 yrs ever since, but the only thing that's come close to that crazy game based on the intensity of insanity was something called the wet blanket treatment a few got during Army training, for "not fitting in". A la the code red in a film called "A Few Good Men" (btw loved that movie, not for Tom cruise but for the brilliant Jack

Nickolson, but I'm digressing). Its been 30 yrs and my back does play up once in a while and I swear, its at the exact spot where my lumbar made contact with that concrete edge. And I repeat, its been 30 yrs, so could someone kindly enlighten me and the rest who never got to play this wonderful sport, as to what exactly the rules were? Please. I'm waiting :))

What ? You all think I'm making this up ? No way 😊

drsatisortho.com That wet knotted towel hit my knee just above the knee cap and was walking around with a double knee for a few days. I can still vividly recall the pain and swelling.

“Arrow in the Dark” — an expertly told comic set-piece about the “Dark Room” hostel hazing game and an injury that still plays up 30 years later.

The Race Between Siddharth and Sanjoy

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 2 May 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

And I have a story about him (and one Sanjoy Mazumdar) too....

Oh what brilliant running, what speed ! In a long distance event ! In four years at RV, if ever I saw pure thrill on those twin football grounds with a cricket pitch neatly linking both, with the cave rock looking on sagely, this was it.

Its not that exciting things hadn't happened earlier. There would be a senior, Gautam N, running in repeatedly, adjacent to the tennis wall, culminating in a final graceful attempt, landing farthest into the long jump pit, farthest ever at RV . On another sandpit, on the ground that morphed into an athletic arena once a year, there was another senior, a six-footer whose name I cannot recall, who leapt highest over and across a cross bar, finished first, and was granted another opportunity to raise the bar, above the RV record. I remember his tears as he crouched in pain in the sandpit, staring at the pole that he had grazed and brought down with him, as it lay, guiltily next to him in the pit.

My classmates were no less either. GM Ashok once threw a cricket ball into a perfect parabola, and once it descended at the other end of the large ground after what seemed an eternity to the seniors, they had to embarrassingly fight for second place. And of course, there was our T.N boy, Dinakar, who ran an 800 metres faster than anybody in RV his age, with classmates setting pace and then disengaging out of the race , one after each lap, like multi-stage rockets sending a satellite into orbit. Frowned upon maybe, but RV has not had that record broken to this day. And there were Mithali and Vishali, who were bent on proving height did not make a difference on the sports field as they went about winning events. One was the tallest, and other the shortest, in our class.

But amongst all this, there was something else. An event for which there were no heats held, before the sports day. The very last event held every year. The long distance run. I do not even remember if it was 3000 mtrs or the 5000 metres. I only remembered it to be a fairly boring event, with slow runners going on forever and ever, round and round and round the 200-metre lap, for what seemed an eternity. To a 13 year old me, who had just witnessed an exciting day of 100 and 200 metre runs, this was boring. But there was a novelty. The one who usually won these long distance runs consistently, was never seen on the sports field the rest of the year. He was on the other side of our imagined spectrum, a yoga/music boy (yes there was a clear demarcation in RV, one was either the sporty types or the yoga/music types). He would effortlessly cross over every year, from the auditorium to the sports field, collect his bounty from long distance running, and stride back quietly, into his world of music and yoga.

Siddharth. This year too. As the run started that late evening, and the participants started to run round and round and round, Siddharth started to build a steady lead with each lap. By mid-race, he had lapped everyone else atleast once over, with his surprisingly un-athletic yet consistent strides. With only 6-7 laps of the little 200-metre oval track left, just as everyone assumed he was running cleanly away, adrenaline.

Pure adrenaline! Sanjoy Mojumdar. A boy 2 yrs my senior. Sanjoy, who like all others in the race, had actually been lapped by Siddharth earlier, started an acceleration, that left everyone who watched that day, astounded. He quickly went past quite a few runners, like in a sprint. And then as he ran down the straights at breath-taking speeds and ran out the curves at an amazing angle, he looked faster than all the sprinters of the shorter

distances earlier in the day. As everyone watched, disbelieving, and unsure if he could keep up this breath-taking sprint, he was in second place, even as he overtook Siddharth, But he still had 200 metres to make up because Sid had earlier lapped him once over.

I will never forget the next few moments. Sanjoy was in a zone of his own as he ran like a man possessed, with everyone's attention on him and his unbelievable speed! As he charged into the last lap, amidst the "will-he, wont-he", this was exciting beyond belief. We the spectators ran in to the ground to get closer to the finish line.

Ultimately, Sanjoy did not beat Siddharth. But came perilously close. As they finished first and second, it truly was a study in contrasts. Siddharth's pace had remained the same from his first stride to his last. Sanjoy, on the other hand, had slept through the race but come alive the last thousand-odd metres. This hare, had started his stupendous burst, a tad late.

Siddharth, after completing that run, went back to where he came from, the auditorium, and a few years later, into the adjacent senior school building, playing an important role(of Principal) there. But my abiding memory of a sports moment in RV remains that. A bolt from the blue Sanjoy, with short stature and long strides, streaking ahead past the other contestants, breezing past Siddharth , and then almost catching up with him all over again, after sprinting ahead an entire lap.

Shabari Padaki OMG

so vivid

Can see it like it was y'day

It was really the "talk of the town" for days on end wasn't it

You really brought it back and brought it alive!

Kartik Kalyanram Wowee. A story for the ages

Prasanna M Nlr Story for the souvenir .

Dechu Kuppanda You should send this story to be added to the stories they are collecting.

overflow.md lists this item's date as 02/12/2026; the message itself is timestamped 02/05/2026, used here.

A masterfully told sports-day story about a legendary photo-finish long-distance race (Siddharth vs Sanjoy Mazumdar); the group itself called it centenary-book material.

Of Curved Sticks and Straight Bats

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 15 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

OF CURVED STICKS AND STRAIGHT BATS

Dr (Capt) Rohit Shetty

I was all of 15, with the 10th board exams done and dusted. In the process of changing schools and in effect, a three month break from hostels, at home in Coorg.

The only sport I could play decently was hockey. And the only decent hockey ground in my small town in Coorg was the hockey ground of the govt school. Off I went with hockey stick in hand, hoping to play a bit and get back in touch with friends.

As I reached the ground, I was surprised to find one of the two goal posts missing. I looked around, and saw two men carrying what appeared to be a carpet. They laid it in the centre of the ground, went back to a corner and reappeared pushing a heavy roller and started rolling it to and fro at the centre of the ground for a few minutes, unrolled the mat, and both started padding up. Yes, just the two of them. As I curiously watched, there emerged a trickle of more men, all in predominantly white rigs.

I went the next day too, and the next. It was the same routine. The two would reach the ground before all others, would actually dig and lift out one goalpost, place it in a corner, roll the pitch, place the mat and wickets, and just as they padded up, rest would appear. As I was to find out later, they were the opening batsmen, and well, if they wanted a pitch with even bounce, they had to reach early and do the hardwork.

All of them would play for an hour or so everyday, wind up, place back the goalpost and leave quietly, much before the local star hockey players made their entry in their colourful outfits and I joined them.

Slowly but surely, it was the cricketers, and their enthusiasm and dedication, that fascinated me. Most of them small businessmen, except one or two "heavyweights" who took it upon themselves to buy the costly expendables like the cricket ball, one new ball every three days. The wicketkeeper managed with hockey goalie pads.

By the fourth day, I was hooked. I put my hockey stick aside, and I asked to be made a part of their team. They corrected me and said its not a team, its a club. And welcomed me . Thus it was that I became the youngest member of the CCC, The Coorgshire Cricket Club. (Though a corny name, it gave the Angrezi touch to the Angrezi game I suppose). But not before they made me get a permission letter from my dad along with a nominal membership fee.

What followed was one of the most memorable times of my life. Most of my "clubmates" were hockey players who had changed "gear"(literally) to cricket. In fact, the eldest member of our club, Mr Halappa, was earlier a star hockey player and during his heydays, had almost made it to the Indian team. It was a treat to watch him bat, tonking and swiping the ball to all parts of the ground in classic hockey style , while his son Arjun Halappa (who was barely six or seven yr old then) dribbled with a tiny hockey stick around us fielders, pretending we were his opponents and flicking his hockey ball onto our shins. Arjun went on to represent India in hockey and also became captain of the national hockey team. I am convinced we the Coorgshire Cricketers and our shins had a major role to play in his success.

From playing passionately, conducting tournaments efficiently the next step. We actually conducted a cricket tournament in that small hockey ground and invited teams from around Coorg and Mysore. Donations were collected, going house to house, for conducting that tournament. People in Coorg have always been generous towards sports and so, we not only conducted that tournament, we even constructed a small pavilion in a corner for visiting teams, with the excess money that we had collected. In fact some teams brought with them "foreign" players, present day IPL style. Foreign, as in league players from Bangalore and a couple of Ranji players too. Arjun Raja and Santhosh Bhavani are two big names I remember.

Drinks breaks saw "golisodas" and end of the matches saw a princely chai and two biscuits. Being the youngest in the club had its advantages...as in extra biscuits. And it had its disadvantages too. I was either twelfth man when the team was playing, or scorer when our team wasn't.

We had our share of pranks too, most of it centering around a pair of identical twins in our team (one a pacer and another a spinner) and using them to confuse our opponents.

That small tournament we conducted had its fallouts. Two or three other cricket teams cropped up, one full of youngsters and aptly called YCC, Youngsters Cricket Club, to whom we would later gladly pass on any extra cricket gears we had.

I have never forgotten Coorgshire Cricketers nor their enthusiasm and passion for the game of cricket, in the midst of a hockey crazy town. That enthusiasm has always stayed with me and even to this day, I am happiest on a cricket field.

Now sadly, it is the game of hockey that is dying. Maybe hockey now requires a dose of the "Coorgshire Cricket Club" .

"Of Curved Sticks and Straight Bats" — a polished, self-authored, bylined essay on discovering cricket in Coorg, the amateur Coorgshire Cricket Club, and a wistful call for hockey's revival.

The TT Final Against Karam

Sathya Gourisankar / Vinod Raj · 5 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Vinod Raj Hi Sathya, are you the person who played a thrilling TT match against Karam ? I heard you live in Atlanta metro area...I live in Marietta. You may remember me as rusum's younger brother.

Sathya Gourisankar Yes Vinod I know you and your brother Vikram. I am that Sathya who played TT match against Karam in the finals of the 1968 championship, I believe the first ever TT tournament organized in RV by Dr Kailasam Sir! Karam was then four years senior to me in ISC class, I was in S1 Junior school, four years younger. It was a best of five games match, I was so short I could not even reach the net from my side of the table! We were level at 2 games all, then I was leading match point at 20-15 in the decider when Dr. Balasundaram stopped the match for a moment, walked up to Karam and whispered a strategy tip to beat me. I ended up winning the match and Karam has remained to this day my very best friend! You just triggered old memories so I am sharing them with a bit of pardonable nostalgia and pride! I have lived in Atlanta since 2013, just retired two years ago from my role as Professor of BME at Georgia Tech. I live in Buckhead area. Yesterday I left you voice mail but did not let my name known so as to surprise you! My tel number is 8173072205. Look forward to being in touch with you. By the way, I am also the oldest RV alum in Atlanta! Best Regards. Sathya

Sathya Gourisankar No Vinod. Docey rooted for Karam. He spoke after the match and said this. "Even though I am happy a junior school kid Sathya wond the match, my heart was with Karam because he is leaving the school next month!" Karam was a huge favorite of Docey, he used to play bridge with him in school and visit him regularly at his farm house in Bangalore long after leaving school. Karam ended being my senior also in REC Tiruchy where he and I did Chem Eng so our association continued and we are in touch now also. Only thing I remember is the junior school kids were rooting for me like crazy because of the thrill seeing one of them beating a senior! Let us met when you areback.

Sathya Gourisankar Vinod, unlike you, I have no regrets about my life long addiction to cricket and justify it to my family and friends along the following lines I have borrowed from another quote: "Of all the insanities that harass Man, Cricket madness is the lesst hatmful and most beneficial!" I will sign off for the day now to catch a bit of sleeo before I can get up to watch the Ashes going on in Brisbsne!

A complete arc from a 1968 TT championship rivalry with "Karam" to a friendship that survived 55 years and continents. (Overlaps the omelette-trade friendship at lines 7092-7094.)

ENTRY 08 OF 42

Dr. Iyer's Blackboard Scores

Sathya Gourisankar · 26 November 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Hari, Even in my time in late sixties through 1972, I used to go regularly to Dr. Iyer's house to listen to Cricket commentary on his short wave radio that was the best one in RV then to catch the short wave bandwidths of 30.1 or 13.9 to get the commentary. Dr. Iyer and I became super friends due to our Cricket addiction. When India was playing Australia in 1967 under Pataudi's captaincy, due to the four or so hours of time difference, I could not go to Dr. Iyer's house due to clash with class times. You know what Dr. Iyer did for my sake? He used to listen to the score every hour or so, then walk into the classroom where I was and as the teacher was teaching, he would quietly write on the top left corner of the black board the score update like Pataudi 75 not out, Suurti 33, etc, and walk out! In 1971, when India was playing England in that famous Oval test under Wadekar's captaincy, Dr. Iyer came to me around evening prep time saying the match is looking very exciting, India might win a historic test and series for the first time ever so why dont you bring any one interested to my house to listen to the commentary, I will cancel your prep and arrange DH to delay your dinners! So we marched to his house and with great excitement heard those legendary English commentators like John Arlott bring alive to us the glorious demolition of England by B.S. Chandrasekhar taking 6 for 38, then Indian batsmen (Vishanath and others) scoring the runs to win a historic match and series! We stayed till the last ball when Abid Ali square cut Luckhurst for four to win the match for us. In those days, cricketing victories were rare and few for Indians which made these types of occasional wins seem more like miracles with added joy. Those in the group who followed the game of seventies can relate to this. I spent many happy hours of my life in RV at Dr. Iyer's house, clutching on to his nice short wave radio of those days!

Dr. Iyer secretly chalking live cricket scores in the corner of the blackboard mid-lesson during a 1967 test; a warm, concrete tribute to a teacher's kindness.

ENTRY 09 OF 42

Look Out of the Window

Sathya Gourisankar and Anita Reddy · 10 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Sathya Gourisankar Seeing the senior school class room with those large windows pics brings back nice memories, one of which I am posting below. Around 1970 or so, our class of 1972 were in the senior assembly listening to a talk by Krishnaji. At one point K mentioned how we should be looking out and staring at nature around us when one of my classmates told K that our teachers will not let us do it during class time! The audience had a laugh at this and then we went for class, with Thomas Akka as the first period. First thing she did that day was to tell that student that he could stare out of the window for as long as he wanted during the class!

Anita Reddy I remember a day when Krishnaji (came to the classroom as he walked in the senior building- if I recollect the place he told us correctly??) And said that we need not look only at the blackboard to learn. We should look out of those big windows (👀) and absorb the beauty of the trees, the flowers in a multitude of hues, the birds and the butterflies! I loved that session , lesson, and teachers had a tough time with our class (of 69) after that😄. Jumping out of the windows is also an old memory - atleast once😄

Two alumni independently recall K telling a student in assembly to stare at nature more, and a teacher immediately honoring it by inviting the boy to gaze out the window. A charming, philosophically perfect moment.

ENTRY 10 OF 42

Prasad Sir's Visit to Atlanta

Sathya Gourisankar · 8 February 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

I met him many times in US since we were living in Dallas area where his son Srinadh was working. One distinct memory comes to mind to share. In his his visit of 2009, I just mentioned to him I went through an all American experience of a corporate lay-off, mid career, at a time when I had to foot the expenses of putting two kids through college. He was so concerned, used to be in regular contact enquiring about our family and six years later, in 2015, when he came to Dallas, he took the trouble of coming over to Atlanta and spending few days with us just to enquire and see how we were doing after going through the tough period of 2009! What a gesture, an unforgettable memory of the love and care of a teacher who went beyond his call of duty to treat a student like his own son! Of course, his English teaching was superb, can never forget how well he taught "To Kill A Mocking Bird, Grapes of Wrath and Julius Caesar" for our class. He gave us such a vivid account in 1972 of the racial divides and culture of American life of those times that I could relate to after moving to Atlanta in 2013, my assistant from Alabama mentioned to me the exact things he used to tell us about the characters of To Kill A Mocking Bird since she hails from that area and confirmed that life there is still pretty much the same as described in that novel and so well articulated by Prasad Sir. We were indeed a blessed and fortunate lot in RV to have had such great teachers cum human beings of tall stature!

A layered tribute to Dr. M.V. Prasad Sir, who stayed in touch after the writer's 2009 layoff and traveled to Atlanta just to check on the family, plus To Kill a Mockingbird coming true in the American South.

ENTRY 11 OF 42

Forgiving Naidu Sir

Uday Bajekal · 13 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

I credit Naidu Sir with putting me off maths because he would hit me across the head hard enough to make me cry when I was 8 or 9. I realised I love numbers many years later and only forgave him when I read about the absolutely incredible work he did to reforest the valley, getting the villagers to place stones on the lee lines and making the tiny precipitation remain and not just run off, taking valuable soil with it, preventing them from letting their goats graze all over the hills etc. Visionary work!

A rare, ambivalent tribute: childhood pain from a teacher who hit him resolved decades later into admiration for Naidu Sir's visionary reforestation work in the valley.

Naidu, You Have Done a Good Job

Sathya Gourisankar · 29 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

B R Venkatesh Met Mr Naidu Sir after his 90th birthday. Couldn't make it on his birthday so went to Maples to meet him. It was such a pleasure to meet him.

Sathya Gourisankar BR, Thank you for sharing these nice pics. I would like to share this about Naidu Sir. Like you, I went to Madanapalle in 2019 on my last RV trip to visit Naidu Sir. He chatted for long about our old times. He and I were Tennis partners, we used to play against Balraj (Marker) and Dr. Balasundaram those days. He narrated about his interesting career and association with RV for over sixty years, how he rejected attractive offers he got from other places like Theosophical Society in Adyar and stayed back at RV. It seems after he finished college at BT College in Madanapalle, G. Narayan Sir (RV Vice Principal) was the one who brought him to RV as PT teacher around 1960 or so. Then, after a long stint, he retired and moved to Madanapalle. One day, he came to RV when K was visiting and he was standing below the residence of K where people used to watch him as he came down for his evening walk. K used to be accompanied by some close associates on his walks but that day, he picked only Naidu Sir and asked him to go for the walk with him. During the walk, K explained to him that RV estate needed good care and someone to manage it well and he would like him to take charge. Naidu sir was hesitant about this and told K he did not have that kind of experience for the role and expressed his hesitation. It seems K somehow convinced him to take it up when Naidu Sir told him he will try it for a year and see how it goes. Then K told him also to ensure good, nutritious local type of food should be given to the farmers and workers. One year later, K returned to RV when Naidu Sir was again standing below K's residence, it seems K looked at him from the balcony on the top floor and said, "Naidu, you can now continue, you have done a good job for the past year!" Naidu sir related this is how he ended up becoming the Estate Manager of RV and now it is history about his monumental contributions to the eco system of RV, profits to school and the wonderful recognition he received with the Vishwa Karma Environmental award from Mrs. Gandhi for water conservation, sustainability, etc! I hope we can all meet this great RV legend during the centenary event and pay our respects to him.

The origin of Naidu Sir's legendary Estate Manager role, singled out by Krishnamurti on a walk and later greeted with "Naidu, you can now continue, you have done a good job." Institutional oral history with photos.

Mark Lee Sir's Last Service to K

Sathya Gourisankar · 16 January 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Sathya Gourisankar Sharing this about the Oak Grove School of KFA in Ojai, CA. Mark Lee Sir left RV in 1973 after teaching from 1965 and returned to Ojai, CA. It seems K wanted to start a school in Ojai but the KFA foundation vetoed him saying there was no money to start a school. Mark Lee Sir says, when K wanted something, he would somehow get it done so he asked Mark Lee to start the school. Mark Lee Sir started the Oak Grove school in 1975 with three children. Today it is a flourishing residential school in Ojai, CA. I read the below account of the first day in that school as narrated by the first teacher hired by the school, Dr. David Moody, published in a recent KFA bulletin which I thought to share with you all for an interesting reading.

[https://oakgroveschool.org/first-day-of-school-remembrance/?](https://oakgroveschool.org/first-day-of-school-remembrance/?utm_source=Krishnamurti+Foundation+of+America&utm_campaign=e7dd61bae6-EMAIL_CAMPAIGN_2025_12_23_05_09&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_cbc037dbbd-e7dd61bae6-132245429&mc_cid=e7dd61bae6&mc_eid=06a53ec4d6)

[utm_source=Krishnamurti+Foundation+of+America&utm_campaign=e7dd61bae6-](https://oakgroveschool.org/first-day-of-school-remembrance/?utm_source=Krishnamurti+Foundation+of+America&utm_campaign=e7dd61bae6-EMAIL_CAMPAIGN_2025_12_23_05_09&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_cbc037dbbd-e7dd61bae6-132245429&mc_cid=e7dd61bae6&mc_eid=06a53ec4d6)

[EMAIL_CAMPAIGN_2025_12_23_05_09&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_cbc037dbbd-e7dd61bae6-](https://oakgroveschool.org/first-day-of-school-remembrance/?utm_source=Krishnamurti+Foundation+of+America&utm_campaign=e7dd61bae6-EMAIL_CAMPAIGN_2025_12_23_05_09&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_cbc037dbbd-e7dd61bae6-132245429&mc_cid=e7dd61bae6&mc_eid=06a53ec4d6)

[132245429&mc_cid=e7dd61bae6&mc_eid=06a53ec4d6](https://oakgroveschool.org/first-day-of-school-remembrance/?utm_source=Krishnamurti+Foundation+of+America&utm_campaign=e7dd61bae6-EMAIL_CAMPAIGN_2025_12_23_05_09&utm_medium=email&utm_term=0_cbc037dbbd-e7dd61bae6-132245429&mc_cid=e7dd61bae6&mc_eid=06a53ec4d6)

Usha K Thank you satya. Wonderful reading about the Oak Grove School. When did you last see Mark Lee sir? Where is he now?

Sathya Gourisankar Usha, Mark Lee Sir passed away I think couple of years ago. I last met him at Ojai, CA in 2017 with my family when my daughter was about to leave for RV to do an internship at RHC under the mentorship of Drs. Kartik and Vidya. I remember him telling her, "You are going to have a wonderful time at Rishi Valley and enjoy the Valley" which was so reassuring to her as she had just graduated from college in US and was going alone for the first time to India for a long stay. His words proved so true, she ended up enjoying her RV life immensely and stayed an extra year as well!

Sathya Gourisankar Yes I remember reading K made his last trip to India in late 1985 when he was in poor health and very frail. One more thing I heard from Mark Lee Sir to share. It seems K told him in his final days at Ojai to ensure his body would be covered with a clean cloth at the funeral home and also to ensure the area of placement of his body be clean and no formal rituals to be performed when he passed away. Mark Lee Sir scrupulously followed the instructions by going under the area of the final location of the body, sweeping it clean with a broom and then placing a clean, white cloth over K's body as the last acts. Imagine the 6ft 4inches Mark Lee Sir crawling under the burial area to keep it spick and span and doing all per K's wish! Mark Lee Sir was the most ardent and devoted follower of K whom I had the fortune to interact with for several years during our time at RV and later!

Mark Lee Sir honoring K's final wishes by personally crawling under the burial site to sweep and cover it with plain white cloth, no rituals. A striking, singular piece of oral history.

ENTRY 14 OF 42

The Sunset Never Changed

Anita Reddy · 23 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

I was 5 years 8months when I joined RVS. That was in 1960. And it was in C1 (class 1 I guess) that I started my learning at school. In 1969, luckily touching my 15th birthday before we could sit for ISC exam. Next 6 months we're those break days before colleges opened in may/ June. In 1970 I was already in my BA English Lit degree course. Leaving Rishi Valley i felt the earth cave under my feet. It had been home especially with all those like venkatesh the bell ringer. Keshavan, paramesh, Gopal etc and the hot Sunday dosas. Chinnaramudu my first mentor in RVS who tried to stop my crying when my parents left me and drove off. Ofcourse all the papammas and venkatammas. Post all these early friends were the wonderful staff and friends like Arun, kamal etc who were there throughout these same years. The escapades were many. But the sunset never changed. And here we are today sharing thoughts with generations who walked out of the portals of our beloved valley.

Feels wonderful 😊

A tender reminiscence of joining RV at age five in 1960, naming the staff who made it home, closing with “the sunset never changed.”

ENTRY 15 OF 42

Serenade at First Bridge

Manisha Arora · 25 November 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Hi Uday, 📺

*To this day, I still remember your rendition of that song
you sang it for us, as I recall, on that group evening walk
when we juniors trailed behind like loyal ducklings. We all stopped near First Bridge,
spellbound, peering down at the glistening pebbles catching the moon's beams like tiny disco balls. And there you
were,
our accidental troubadour,
serenading the night
as if the whole valley were your stage and we were the most important audience you'd ever have. 🙌*

A short free-verse poem to a senior who sang on a moonlit evening walk near First Bridge, juniors trailing “like loyal ducklings.” An actual alumna-composed poem.

ENTRY 16 OF 42

On Krishnaji's Lap

Lalasa · 22 November 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Before we used to have under the Neem tree behind red and green houses 🏠 kji sitting on those rock benches watching us little kids. I sitting on his lap with his arms around me holding my hand looking into his gentle eyes. I still feel the warmth Where we met. UK. USA. He asked if I was comfortable. What a VISIONARY.

A rare, intimate first-person memory of sitting on J. Krishnamurti's lap as a small child under the Neem tree, recalling his gentle eyes and warmth.

ENTRY 17 OF 42

An Envelope for Hans Herzberger

Sumana · 15 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

In 1984 I took an introductory philosophy class at the University of Toronto, as a pre-med student. My TA in the portion of the class that was symbolic logic became a friend. When he heard that I was headed to India for the summer he asked if I would take an envelope for him. Canada Post was notoriously slow and he wanted comments back from his thesis supervisor asap. I took one look and was stunned. The envelope was addressed to Hans Herzberger in Rishi Valley. Achille Varzi told me his professor had just been splitting his time between Toronto and the valley in the summers. I hand carried the envelope and met Hans and Radhika akka in RV. That began a relationship that in time led both my brother and I to send our children to RV and my brother Sanjay to teach for a term. I remember Hans' quiet interest and Radhika akka's encouragement and support in so many ways.

An improbable errand — hand-carrying an envelope from a Toronto TA to Hans Herzberger at RV — that forged a lasting multi-generational family connection to the school.

Thirty-Nine Years to Cave Rock

B R Venkatesh, S Thomas, Vibhu, Ram R, Gautam Mahmood · 12 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

B R Venkatesh 39 years after leaving RV I finally went upto the cave rock. Shocking isn't it.

Fear of thorns, snakes and sheer laziness prevented me from exploring this hill. There was no clear path to cave rock.

The need of the hour was to photograph the valley from cave rock.

Got up early to catch the valley as the sun rose in the east behind the hill.

The view I experienced was exceptional.

Lush green Valley , the 'A' field to the right, the 3 iconic mountains (Bodi Konda, Central peak , Rishi kinda to the left, the Horsley hills , in front of it the 3 sisters rock, below that Tettu village I presume. Just missed the sliding rock.

Dont miss the shadow of the Cave rock in the foreground.

Spent a good amount of time at the cave, wanted to explore the cave but the fear of getting stuck in the cave prevented me.

Enjoyed the sights, the gentle breeze, the smell of the valley, the very fresh air, - total relaxation.

Wanted to spend more time there when the sound of the DH bell pealed across the valley. With my stomach grwling i rushed back in time for hot Dosas

S Thomas I happened to accompany BR to the Cave Rock. It almost became a mission to do so, considering this was his first time ever. We were looking for the 'exact' spot from which a particular b&w photograph of the Valley was taken in 1926 by the Theosophists. An RV with no buildings. Just fallow fields and familiar tamarind and neem trees.

At the end of the Cave Rock 'expedition' that day, we think we found the exact spot and BR took a few of our own.

S Thomas Gautam, be patient 😊 . Its in the book you just ordered.

Vibhu Did you go traverse a ghat section Sunil

S Thomas You need BR's skills to perceive a ghat section that barely exists 😊

Vibhu He breaks into a cold sweat in the ghats

S Thomas But BR being one of three lead photographers, I had a selfish interest in taking him up to Cave Rock safely, so that the camera (that resembled a bazooka) didnt go tumbling down with him.

S Thomas Thats me with part of BR's equipment. I was appointed Sherpa throughout his trip to RV, first in 2018, then again in 2019.

S Thomas Also 6 b&w photographs from 1926 from different angles of the Valley, never before published until now, thanks to the archives in KFEngland.

Ram R I cherish my copy. Wonderful book, Sunil !

Kamashree Thadepalli Truly.

And the print and layout are so well planned and coffee-tableesque

BR Venkatesh finally hikes Cave Rock 39 years on, turning into an intergenerational detective story about recreating a 1926 photo of the valley before any buildings existed.

ENTRY 19 OF 42

Crabs in the Flood Stream

Deepali Mody · 11 October 2025 · RVS Centenary 2026 WhatsApp

Yes, my most enduring memory of RV is playing in the stream at first and second bridge after a flash flood of rain and then when the waters dispersed finding crabs and other little unexpected creatures in the bed.

Coming back to blue house I was expecting a dressing down from parchure akka for the dishevelled sopping wet from head to toe state I was in but instead only received a kindly smile and an instruction to go take a good bath.

Playing in the flood-swollen stream and finding crabs, then returning soaked to Blue House expecting a scolding from Parchure Akka but receiving only a kindly smile.

ENTRY 20 OF 42

School-Sick

Dechu Kuppanda · 24 May 2025 · RVS Centenary 2026 WhatsApp

Dechu Kuppanda When I finished my ICSE in 1981 my parents did not want me to go back for my +2. I was so school sick!! Many a Fridays I would tell my parents I was going to school.

It meant I had to go to City Market in Bangalore (not a great place for a 16 year old girl to hang out). Catch the Madanapalle bus from Bangalore, get on the Thittu Village bus at Madanapalle, get off at Signpost and walk to school. I did this so many times that year! I would spend a night at school and head back.

Amazingly, my parents just let me go.

Nagi Narayanan How lovely ... So beautiful a relationship has been created at RV.

So school-sick after ICSE that she secretly made a multi-bus journey back to RV on weekends just to spend a night, and her parents simply let her.

ENTRY 21 OF 42

Is There Anyone Who Really Knew Him?

M · 22 August 2025 · RVS Centenary 2026 WhatsApp

Sivarajan sir was an elusive human being. But standing outside his house hiding and listening to him play the sitar as Little kid was indeed a treat. A master of many crafts his aero modelling classes were very sought after, during our time. He was such a mysterious man but one of immense love for music and art. He would be locked away in his dingy room in the art and craft section up to something always. Also he was the one who started the craze of kites among many kids and helped people make beautiful kites.

Is there anyone who really knew him?

Just curious if anyone got closer to him during or after his time at RV?

A second vivid Sivarajan sir tribute: hiding as a child to listen to his secret sitar, his aeromodelling classes and kite-making craze, closing on "Is there anyone who really knew him?"

Remembering Jim Fowler

Sathya Gourisankar, Arun Joshi, Usha K, Sridhar Pennathur, Vinod Raj, Shivanand Reddy, Paru Kona and others · 2 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Arun Joshi Jim Fowler Sir taught me Mechanical Drawing in '68 & '69.

Usha K Jim fowler taught us yoga, English Grammer, and would take part in folk dance on Sundays. I had to take very big steps when dancing because of his tall stature. Kind yet strict, a wonderful person.

Sathya Gourisankar Since there are lot of recollections posted about Jim Fowler, I am sharing below my post on the RV Centenary planning group which I posted a while ago, hoping it will trigger some more happy memories of this great teacher in this group. "Dear RVites, As the planning is being discussed for next year's event, I am reminded of the following which might trigger some happy memories for many who were involved in an earlier era. It was 1969 I think when there was a big get together in RV of K followers from a number of countries. It was called the Gathering if I remember correctly. Many visitors were accommodated in tents pitched behind the Neem hostels of those times. The S4 class (now called 11th std) students were given the charge of looking after the arrangements for the visitors with the bonus of having no classes for two weeks or so. Special food was arranged in the dance cottage and other cottages for the westerners. Since it was during the school term, many of the students got to interact with some interesting folks from various countries. One special thing I could relate to was an Englishman who came for that gathering by name Jim Fowler. After the gathering, Jim stayed back and taught math to our class (batch of 1972), on subjects such as Geometric drawing, algebra, etc. He went on to work at RV as math teacher for over 7 years before returning to UK! There must be a number of you from that era who were actively involved in that grand event at RV who can narrate many more details of that gathering! If Prasad Sir (our Senior School English teacher of those times) is in this group, he can be a great one to share his thoughts on how the school managed such a big get together for about two weeks in those days! Sathya Gourisankar (ISC, 1972)"

Sathya Gourisankar He was also big in hiking and used to take assemblies describing his tough hike to Mt Kilimanjaro in Africa as well as his adventures with Bedouins in Arabia, two I recollect! I heard from Mark Lee sir many years later that after RV, he went to stay at Monasteries in various places. One other thing about him. Even in RV, he used to live as a hermit, very frugal and simple life, students used to joke he had only two pants and shirts which he wore throughout his years of stay there. Reflecting back, I think he was a great example of a minimalist who practiced simple living, high thinking!

Usha K If he came in '69, the tenure as a teacher cannot be more than five years. I joined in '69 and left in '73. He left before we left.

Sridhar Pennathur I remember Jim Fowler as our English Language teacher in S2 and perhaps S3 as well (1970-1971). One of my favorite memories are the "Précis" assignments he would give us. The objective was to condense a long document down to a certain number of words. I used to wonder why he made us do it and only realized the value much later on when I had to write my thesis and subsequently scientific papers that had strict requirements for length. In retrospect, I am very grateful to Jim Sir for helping me with my writing skills.

Sathya Gourisankar Yes Usha he must have been there about five years based on this memory also. I think around 1972 he went to Bangalore for treatment of a heart problem and soon after his return told some of us over lunch he was planning to go back to UK shortly. I asked him why he was leaving RV and remember his stern reply to this day: "How would you like to be away from your home for so many years!"

Divya Bidapa Interesting anecdotes of early life in RV. It would be nice to meet Mr. Jim Fowler, or at least hear him say something about his days in RV.

Vinod Raj Jim Fowler had a bullet wound on his back... did you guys know he was a spy during WW2?

Divya Bidapa Oh wow!! It's getting more and more exciting now😄

Appala Raju Wow, I vaguely remember that Jim Fowler found some pre-historic tools and items and it was discussed that the cave was once inhabited.

Shivanand Reddy 1968 or so, some of us including Jim Fowler, were in the RV swimming pool when I noticed and asked him about the small midriff indentation below his right shoulder blade.

Said he fell off a telegraph pole somewhere in Iran.

He was a WW2 telecoms engineer, fixing comms lines is what he told me.

No mention of any spooky work.

Paru Kona Jim Fowler taught Mechanical drawing and yoga too. I was in both of his classes.

overflow.md's stated source lines (2781–2808) and date (23/09/2025) for this item do not match its own summary — those lines hold an unrelated consciousness/philosophy exchange. The correct thread was located at alumni lines ≈2065–2178, dated 02–03/12/2025, and is reproduced above with the tangential class-photo identification chatter edited out for coherence, per overflow.md's own note that multi-voice threads “may require editorial care.”

A multi-voice oral history of eccentric teacher Jim Fowler and the 1969 “Gathering,” full of vivid detail (the mysterious bullet wound, the pre-historic cave tools, the folk-dance lineage).

ENTRY 23 OF 42

I Have a Hundred Eyes

Shankar S.V, Prasanna M Nlr, Rashmitha, K Ramesh, Kartik Kalyanram · 15 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Shankar S.V A hostel that brings back memories of Sati Bai Akka. Almost all our generation of students would recollect her " I'll give you properly " mild mannered scold with a hint of humour in the tone.....and Two great friends on the lawn in-between Red & Blue houses !

Kamashree Thadepalli She was ageless

K Ramesh Very true.Sathibai akka was so caring,yet a disciplinarian.

Prasanna M Nlr 1st time I am seeing Padma akka without a broad grin . She use to light up anywhere she was . Great lady , w/o a great man & m/o great children .

"I have a 100p eyes . I know the culprit . If he (never "she") confesses , I'll let him off lightly for telling the truth" , Sathibai akka . Idiots like us would fall for it & confess . She would let us off with an ear-pinch/ squeeze .

Prasanna M Nlr 1000 eyes .

Rashmitha She measured my shorts once and accused me of dating a boy from my class with whom I had a 'who gets the Time magazine first' contest! Hahaha

Rashmitha Two separate incidents

Kartik Kalyanram When Satibai akka left school, Aruna Reddy (ISC 72) took over and carried on the traditions. When Aruna left Mani akka, who taught bio for a couple of years was the house parent. Then in 2005, when our daughter completed her ISC, self and Vidya (my wife took over). We were house parents for 04 years.

A warm multi-voice tribute to houseparent Sati Bai Akka (“I have 100 eyes, I know the culprit”), capped by the full houseparent lineage down to Kartik and his wife.

Five Children for Fifty Rupees

Jayanth Gutta · 7 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Amazing biography of Mr. G V Subbarao. He was the principal when my mother studied at RV. SHE LOVED HIM. Visited him every time when she went to Chennai (Madras). Sent a gift check every year on his birthday.

Short story of my grandfather. Ardent follower of Krishnaji.

He was hospitalized at Arogyavaram for Tuberculosis. Came to know about a school close by. During his convalescence he disappeared from the sanitarium and walked to the school to find out about it. He always believed in education. He had completed BSc in agriculture. Got a job with the British government and was managing their farms.

He had a daughter and son and under his wing were his brothers 2 daughters who were orphaned.

He went to RV and requested admission for the 4 children and also to his young sister-in-law who is Monorama's mother. When the question of school fees came up he stated his difficulties. He said he makes Rs 100/month. GV Subbarao told him he can pay whatever he can. My grandfather payed Rs 50/ month for all 5 of them and that was half of his salary.

Manorama's mother became member of parliament but unfortunately her life was cut short when Mano was in school. Next was grandfather's brother's daughter who did library sciences and became head at JNU in Delhi. My mother turned out to be a Gynecologist. My maternal uncle joined Indian oil and went up in ranks. The second daughter of my grand father's brother became Director of FCI in charge of South zone of India.

They are the products of GV SUBBARAO. All 5 of them loved him and used talk of him when ever RV was in discussion.

My grandfather didn't stop there. Prasad sir's father and my grandfather were buddies from childhood. With that connection he put me in the school and Manorama followed the following term and later Shailu from Madanapalle and her brother GV. Soon after my sister Jayashree and cousin Sandhya also joined. My grandfather used to visit me every term for few days staying at Madanapalle coming by bus and walking to school from the Mouth. Attended Krishnaji's talks every year.

Sorry guys to bore you with this.

A multi-generational family history: a TB-recovering grandfather negotiating reduced fees with founding principal G.V. Subbarao for five children, all of whom went on to notable careers.

The Bear at Echo Rock

Kartik Kalyanram, Sathya Gourisankar, Shankar S.V · 15 March 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Kartik Kalyanram Sathya correction Not petromax lanterns but simple kerosene ones.

After they crossed the jackals would come out

Sathya Gourisankar Yes Kartik you are right. We used to see them trekking with the lamps from our New Hostel, they would march across the ground!

Shankar S.V Seen many streaking across the cricket field in front of my house (foxes too) and vanish in the hill towards lost lake especially very early in the mornings

Kartik Kalyanram Shankar, I remember a story about Dad stepping out and spotting a leopard on his verandah?

Harsha ...don't they come pre-spotted?

Kartik Kalyanram Ha ha they have rosettes

Kartik Kalyanram Fortunately Venks sir used bright pink paint

Shankar S.V Hehehe...not true Karthik

Sathya Gourisankar I wonder how nicely the Valley has turned out for a school with the landscape fitting so beautifully as though designed and tailor made for K's vision! Those patches of water in wells, hiking areas, trails leading to nearby villages, etc - seem so designer based

Usha K Also the the running stream in rainy season under the first bridge.

Shankar S.V Karthik, however once when dad took a hiking group to Rishi konda and then on to Horsely hills, they had to stop for the night on a large Flat rock. He collected sticks and dry bushes and kept them all round the rock and lit them up to ward off any animals. He stood guard the whole night and sure enough a big bear lumbered up and after watching for few minutes went on its way because of the fire and embers. That's the closest call He has had during his tenure.

After reaching Horsely hills, that night he flashed a very powerful torch off & on from echo rock on top many times, just to tell Dr. SB they had reached. Mr. John switched off and on the lights of the school in response. I recollect most students and teachers viewed this from the Asthachal place.

A cinematic true story: a hiking group ringed by fire to keep a bear away overnight, then a torch-signal flashed from Echo Rock and answered by the school's lights, watched from Asthachal.

Watching Them Drive Away

Uday Bajekal, Sathya Gourisankar · 17 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Uday Bajekal <https://www.bbc.co.uk/programmes/m0027157>

Uday Bajekal Some of what Nicky Campbell says certainly resonates - "the feeling of abandonment when you watch your parents car driving away from school and realise no one is coming back for you"! I used to cry even aged 16, leaving Rourkela for RVS and then forget about my family within two or three days!

Uday Bajekal My wife said I should listen to this programme and I shed tears listening to all three of the programmes. I used to tell my wife Madhavi, that we should send our daughter Anjali to RVS. Madhavi is too intelligent to argue with me. So she suggested that we send Anjali to India alone for one month. Two weeks with my parents and two with hers. Waving our delighted, grinning daughter (aged 7) off at Heathrow Airport (holding the hand of her BA stewardess) I cried so much that a security guard came to me, hugged me and said "Your wife said she's coming back soon Sir! Don't cry!"

Uday Bajekal Needless to say-all talk about sending Anjali to RVS came to an abrupt halt!

Uday Bajekal Many years later Anjali and my wife visited RVS, saw my room (cement beds, three nestled close together-Bhaskar Reddy, Ramesh Reddy and me) the rather smelly toilets with no flush systems and Anjali turned to me and said "You cannot have lived here for two years dad!"

Uday Bajekal They lived meeting the students though! Thought they were so intelligent and my wife called one girl "vivacious" and then her classmates teased her mercilessly "Oh miss vivacious!"

Uday Bajekal Loved not lived

Sathya Gourisankar Nice One Uday. I can relate to your story with mine this way. My daughter Amritha, after completing her Bachelors in Biomedical Eng at Washington University, St Louis, got a rare chance of a lifetime a Fulbright scholarship and that too to work on Public health research and guess where, at RV Rural Health center, under the extraordinary care and loving mentorship of Drs. Kartik and Vidya (whom she considers her role models as physicians and healers). This was in 2017 August. Just couple of weeks earlier, we all as a family met with Mark Lee Sir and Asha Akka at their home in Ojai, CA. When I told him about Amritha's impending visit to RV, he was so overjoyed and exuberantly told her, she is going to have the best time of her life there! I still recollect with emotion, the passion and conviction with which Mark Lee Sir assured this kid about to go to a vastly different part of the world that she is going to have a ball there. She did enjoy her life in RV so much that after completing one year at RV (staying in a room on top of Malli house), she accepted a role with RHC to extend her stay for another year, learnt a bit of Telugu, taught Spanish to kids at RV, relished the spicy pickles and local food there including the famous Thettu Dosa it seems in the village (which I am yet to taste) and returned to US to pursue medicine with her interests defined in the area of rural and global public health. I write this with lot of nostalgia cum gratitude to Providence and Drs. Kartik and Vidya for their extraordinary mentorship that contributed so much to Amritha's interests in pursuing medicine as a career and along the way getting to appreciate many elements of Indian culture, notably in relishing hot, spicy pickles (Avakkai and such) as well as Dosa, Idli, Upma and so on! Because of Mark Lee Sir's assurance which he spoke in a manner of giving as a guarantee, I did not shed a drop of tear as I waved Amritha good bye in Atlanta international airport on her trip to India. After her stint in RV, she wrote the following about her first moments of RV upon arrival - "Onti gantaku cliniculo doctor tho kalavali" (meet the doctor in the clinic at 1 pm) saying which the man dropped off my luggage at my new room. I had just landed in rural India - seemingly in the middle of nowhere, but in reality, just couple of hours from my "roots" - father's hometown, one I had passed through many times on the way to my

grandparents' house. The current journey to this rural village, however, started not on one of those childhood trips, but during my sophomore year of college in the operating room of a pediatric cardiologist and her five-year old patient." Sorry for the verbose post, when it comes to sharing matters from the heart with nostalgia and fond memories, I am not able to get bogged down by restraints on word count, or brevity and such!

Two parallel, tender parent stories about children's relationship to RV across a generation, including a daughter's own words on first arriving at the Rural Health Centre.

ENTRY 27 OF 42

You Are Not What You Appear to Be

Sathya Gourisankar · 12 June 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Honesty demands I add this. Only Thomas Akkla saw through my mischief and one time caught me in act of planned escapade to watch a movie in Bangalore when we were on an excursion for which she was the escort, in 1971. She knew all about the midnight escape I had plotted with few of my mates but next morning was super gracious and chose to forgive us but came to my table at breakfast and made this poignant remark looking into my eyes which I recollect to this day: "Sathyamurthy, you are not what you appear to be!" She said it so pleasantly, it did not sink into me until many years later when I understood it better upon reflection. Sunil, sharing this one specially for you, Akka treated me with out of the world kindness during my school years (even though I was not a biology student beyond 9th grade) and even later on my visits as alum, I have some more interesting incidents to narrate. Do remember me to her with my warmest regards and wishes for her good health. Thank you.

Thomas Akka catching a planned midnight movie-escape but forgiving with grace, saying only "Sathyamurthy, you are not what you appear to be." A disarming small moment.

ENTRY 28 OF 42

Valley Re-Discovered

Udit Chaudhuri (shared by Sathya Gourisankar) · 24 November 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Same here Narendra, he was my dear friend, neighbor in class and often we corresponded by email soon after internet was born in the nineties which greatly helped in getting us connected. I share below in his honor the lovely article he wrote of the class 1972 reunion of the nineties (I think 1999) which I have saved and read periodically. Since it captures a lot of the magic and aura of the valley that alums across batches can relate to, I am pasting it below for the reading pleasure of this group.

Valley Re-Discovered

by Udit Chaudhuri

We all long to visit Rishi Valley as old students. And some of us yearn to give something of the RV we've carried with us. First the distance makes a short trip unworthy. Matching others' schedules is another hurdle. College, job and family priorities clash. Finally we wonder "who'll know us relics out there?" by which time we've lost touch with everyone else, getting middle-aged and cynical. The old dream floats away . . . Well, this one came true over 1st - 3rd October '99 and how! You can be part of the second one. Udit Chaudhuri (ISC '72) relates.

". . . Guess who!" said a strange caller from Bangalore on a muggy August evening, as if he saw me daily. I shot in the dark: "From school? You're Shivanand Reddy!" as if he lived next door. Hearing each other first time after December 1972, were we both floored by our responses!

Nostalgia apart, I was keen to visit the school to see:

- How much or what of Rishi Valley education or values had each of us had borne over the years;
- Development work, especially in afforestation, water management and rural education that we heard of;
- What we can give back which is deliverable, without setting ambitious goals or making tall promises.

I have tried to describe all experiences below, but the second needs to be seen to be believed!

Meanwhile a massive manhunt was on. Shivanand and Gowri Shanker on the Net and telephone hunted down everyone in the class or their whereabouts except Shanker Subramaniam Ghoda, Baba (marine engineer; Where the ____ are you, man!) locating 16 in India by mid September. These were: Aruna (nee Dhote, now teaching at RVS and) and husband Shiv, Shivanand Reddy, Shendy, senior communications executive); Anand Reddy, Kodi (brother of Sreelatha Chitti, ISC '70; successful industrialist) Varsha (nee Prabhu, sister of Milind, ISC '69) and Suvarnarekha (Head of Paediatrics at St John's Hospital) all from Bangalore; Gowri Shanker Garry (now an industrialist at Chennai), TK Ramkumar Rom (lawyer, environmentalist and President of civic movement EXNORA), PS Ramdass, Doss (hotelier of Vega fame) Venku Reddy (financial consultant), Sashikala Reddy, Malini Krishnamurthy (nee Anandaram, sister of Raj, ISC '70 and Srikanth ISC '75?) and Prabhakar Reddy (civil contractor - largest owner of L&T-Poclain machines!) from Chennai; Shiavax J Vazifdar variously Shark, Dorrai, Bava (brother of Homi, ISC '67; Successful lawyer forever tied up in 'dozen 'matters'! at HC and SC levels) and yrs truly, Tidu (brother of Shubha, ISC '68 and Itu, ISC '77; Struggling tech copywriter & consultant) from Mumbai; RVL Ramchandra, Sanda (entrepreneur, also in environmental engg) from Hyderabad; Narendra Patwardhan, Naren (brother of Swati, ISC '68; CA and senior financial executive) from Pune. Contacted barely a week ahead, he cancelled all engagements to make it. And instantly recognised Shivanand on the phone after a good 30 years!

This one journey to RVS gave no butterflies in the stomach with each approaching day. No squabbles with parents for more 'grub' and tins to smuggle, no dispute on the choice of clothes and no goading to pack. No book-laden trunks and stuffed hold-alls either. At Bangalore, Shiavax, Narendra and I were duly marinated and stuffed like pate-geese by Shivanand and Anand Reddy at the KGA Club and we spent the 30th Sep night at Shivanand's flat rolling with laughter, recalling all our foibles. Woken up at 5 am by Mr Venks' chanting (recorded, of course) of Suprabhatam, we set off.

Gliding in Shivanand's Esteem, four of us reached RVS mid-morning, taking the longer but smoother Madras Road. The change in landscape struck us from the Mouth of the Valley. An engineering college threatening to come up. Lion Rock as it was. Car Rock split by quarrying (a sports car?). Grand Canyon half eroded, half greened. And lo! - no sight of the school from as close as the Tamarind Grove! A dense tree cover. Coconut grove, fruit orchard and paddy in fields where only groundnut and millets grew. Signpost missing at its fork, Sericulture Centre adjacent to it. Elementary School now Rural Education Centre, a modern, tile roofed brown-painted brick-walled quadrangular and cottage-sized buildings showing all concepts of solar design and environment-friendly architecture, straight out of Discovery Channel! Bushes, a canal and hard soil under the 2nd and 1st Bridges instead of sand, where we jumped to hide from Dr Iyer, Mr Venks or Naidu Sir at PT time!

The Office is now all hi-tech. Computers, fax machines and hooked to a digital RAX that connects you anywhere in seconds! No Internet connectivity yet, though. Stocks of colour film, should you need any. (I did, the very next day!) A publication unit sells The Book of Chants & Songs as you remember them. Narayanappa's Post Office has moved to its own building. State bank of Mysore has an Extension Counter thereabouts. We stopped at the adjacent Car Park to abandon cars for the next 52 hours. No vehicles or smoking beyond this point, Shivanand warned us all.

Reaching the ageless bouganvillea covered Senior School Building (the same palm tree at the centre of the quadrangle!) at Tea Break, we marched straight into the Staff Room - no ticking off this time! Same chairs but more rows. The big windows at jumping height. But a difference: Strange faces stared agape as thumps, punches and bear hugs were swapped between a somewhat mellow Naidu Sir, an ageless Mishraji and our own Arunakka who fired us for missing the Assembly. As usual, the delay was my fault – not the long route nor breakfast at Woody's. Over cups of tea we were introduced to Dr Sailesh Shirali the principal, Dr A Kumaraswami the Secretary of RV Education Centre, Mr Shailendran the Bursar, Mr Alok Mathur the Junior School Head, Mr Rangaswami heading the Institute of Bird Studies and Natural History as well as all senior staff. It was also a pleasant surprise to see Kartik Kalyanraman from the '77 batch having joined as Health Officer of the Rural Education Centre after about 18 years of service in the Air Force.

Naidu Sir then took charge, marching us around the campus. Aruna insisted on going back to her classes despite 'hints' from her students to 'look after her classmates'.

The new Children's' School building, next to the solid old Junior School is another quadrangular structure with spotlessly clean floors, covered porches for multiple use, neat geometric shapes, ample rooms, corridors and garden, earthy colours all over, neatly arranged functional furniture shining with paint, tidy racks full of neatly arranged and plenty of children's books and educational material. Simple yet elegant in appearance. Sathibai Akka greeted us, remembering all our names and introduced us to all the children. She runs that and the Red House under her total control, nearing eighty years in age, with all the dedication, perfection and discipline as ever.

Moving to the Arts & Crafts dept next door, we saw that stepped up too. The old carpentry shed converted into batik / textile design studio with permanent dyeing facility; old batik room converted into a weaving class with lots of tiny looms; Raju Mama's den expanded into a carpentry workshop with machinery to compete with a small factory; the old pottery and painting areas all covered, equipped with electric wheel, a host of facilities and a crafts/hobbies workshop adjacent with a wood carving and model-making section as well! The output is exceptional, with children conceptualising a variety of furniture, models of windmills, gliders, rubber-propelled airplanes, sculptures, paintings and designed fabrics that can stand up to an art college! There is a team of dedicated staff for each section. I asked them to think of exhibiting the work at places like Bangalore to begin with.

Nearing noon, we walked across the games field, enlarged in size by filling up the rivulet at the foot of Cave Rock Hill. And keeping with Olympic standards. Four tennis courts and basketball courts where throw-ball and ring-tennis were played. Sub-junior field is now Hockey ground, surrounded by more quarters along with the old houses of Mr Venks (now an educational consultant at Chennai) and Naidu Sir, who now stays overnight at Madanapalle with his daughter and grandchildren, being picked up and dropped by the school's Sumo. At the start of the boulder path to Boat Rock stands an international standard indoor games building. The old Swimming Pool is closed. Football and basketball are favourites while cricket is not played as frequently. PT for juniors is discontinued.

Walking from the fields to the DH (Dining Hall) one could see many more pretty villa-type structures - students' Houses and staff quarters what with the greater strength and close student-staff ratio. Yet I could not photograph most of them as there were trees all over. Some with thatched roofs, some emulating adobe huts. The main lawn is still there, lush and full of blossoming plants although not as neatly manicured. And there is the old sun dial, built under Mr NS Ganesan's direction assisted by 5-6 students including me in 1970! Houses/hostels are no more age-wise like our time. There are many more, each accommodating distributed age groups of boys or girls. Mostly named after a flower. Each room occupied by 4-6 students. With space or books, desk for prep and perhaps double the carpet area per student. A remarkable pattern emerges: brickwork, some adobe- emulated construction; less of stone masonry than before, possibly to discourage quarrying and higher labour costs; local material used in proportion to cement and concrete; porches, shades, roofing in pyramid , convoluted or conical shapes - tiled, cement, lime mortar (?) or thatched; quadrangular layout; lawns, flower-beds and rock gardens in each quadrangle; Eucalyptus, gulmohar and hibiscus surrounding all of them and all painted in earthy colours. Indeed (the late) Nari Gandhi left his stamp on Rishi Valley architecture. Total harmony with the landscape. In contrast, New Hostel of our times (now re-named) stands out quite harsh (weren't we right in calling it Central Jail!) but for the surrounding growths of gulmohar and eucalyptus.

We could not help noticing the enhanced use of technology. The old labs all beefed up, even a storey higher. They are supported by computer rooms and AV rooms, including scanning and image editing. I was able to scan and restore an old photograph of our class in RVL Ramchandra's possession and caption it, using the latest Adobe products on a Pentium II -based PC and take laser prints for everyone! Solar absorption panels for hot water cap nearly every hostel. Bicycles and two wheelers are all over the permitted tracks. The laundry is automated. The kitchen is full of processing and handling machinery as are the pantry and bakery - down to a bread-slicing machine! Biogas-fired burners at a number of locations. And although the senior school building looks the same its library has expanded and a large variety of study materials are used. A fleet of Tata Sumos and a Tempo Traveller as against just one school-owned Ambassador (still there!) and Willy's van earlier. Somewhat a picture of ideal rural development.

Another striking sight is the presence of waste bins, separately marked "PLASTICS" all over. Further, at the Guest House there is a placard in each room instructing the use of the right bins for each type of waste, along with an appeal to carry non-degradable wastes back to the city. Part of this stems from the fact that Krishnaji's concern about the human race's responsibility to the bio-environment had, over the years, developed into higher emphasis on environmental education and awareness. The Institute of Bird Studies and Natural History is a culmination of all this. More about this later.

By lunch, Anand Reddy drove in from Bangalore followed by RVL Ramchandra from Hyderabad with wife Devika, children Pawan and Shreya (the three did yeomen's service in photographing us as a group everywhere we went) and the Chennai contingent Gowri, Ramdass, Ramkumar, Malini and Venku - all disappointed that "Kanti" at Madanapalli had closed, hungry, tired but full of gusto. Another round of greetings. More news of this one and that. Some good, little bad. Same faces, marginal east-west growth and a sprinkling of salt n' pepper over the top. As we sat waiting outside the DH, all dressed pretty with creepers and flowering plants and a hat of solar panels, Mishraji and Naidu Sir reminded us of all our exploits in evading PT & Games and their efforts to nab us. Like the time Gowri climbed to the New Hostel upper floor bathing courtyard wall and scaled down the pipes only to run smack into Naidu Sir! I recalled Mishraji standing right next to me shivering under a cement cot one winter morning and going away away quietly. In the DH one could not help recalling the film song, lead by S4 and ISC '70 boys, "to inaugurate the new DH" when the silence bell had rung - and the subsequent thunder from Meenakshi Akka and Dr Balasundaram!

We retired briefly at the New Guest House. Comfortable clean rooms with linen, towels soap – 5 Star standards for our times! Kept spic and span by Gopala the 'in-charge' attendant who seemed to remember about all of us from our pictures in old copies of the School Magazine and old photographs he had preserved and pored over. He traced me to my brother, Itu and sister Shubha by deduction from that material! There were more recollections and confessions by all classmates, spiced by the Venku Reddy brand of one-liners.

Getting together, each recalled their exploits and like Mr RV Ramanan pronouncing Shivanand and Venku 'congenital idiots' (whatever it meant) in perfect 'BBC English' for hiding in their lockers at PT time. But Shiavax still denied pulling the alarm chain on the Bombay-Madras Exp. And I still refuse to admit any involvement in cutting Janardhan's bicycle tube to make a bigger catapult or in the attempt to steal Mr Achutan's moped – the only two-wheeler on the campus those days!

Late afternoon, Naidu Sir again took us to see the afforestation and watershed development along the range of hills parallel to his old quarters, DH, Asthachal and beyond the Guest House. We had been hearing about it, but to see it in reality, with Naidu Sir's narration was another experience. With some help of students and some labour, he had planted seeds and saplings all over the campus and the hillside, right up to our old Lost Lake and Tree Top Secret. The trees included eucalyptus sandalwood, and drought-resistant varieties like acacia and red sanders, the last of which commands a very high premium in the export market. He had improvised a substitute to the drip irrigation system that worked until there was sufficient transpiration from the all-round growth and rain-water percolation, for self-perpetuating vegetation. He harvested rain- water by building a series of Contour Bunds, running along the strike-line of the hill slope, at close intervals. This prevented run-off.

The Lost Lake became part reservoir, part forest. Now the trees are worth an astronomical sum, having multiplied by natural dispersion. He went on to relate his patently no-nonsense approach in pursuing assistance from the political bigwigs and bureaucrats, reminiscent of "No hands and legs (complaints). I want (you in the) PT field!" All efforts paid off as can be seen from the dense tree cover all around. About 300% increase in biomass is reported, all over the area. And Naidu Sir was awarded the Indira Priyadarshini "Vrikshamitra" in 1997. And the school had earned a good income from the sale of produce from this forest. Naidu Sir also visited our sister schools at Ojai, Oak Grove, Brockwood Park as well as the Chestland Flower Show, Kew Gardens, other gardening and afforestation sites.

As we climbed the hill listening to Naidu Sir we could not but marvel at the visible achievement of this man, against such odds. With minimal inputs, severe set-backs in family life and the additional responsibility of managing the entire Estate. Single-minded devotion and robust pragmatism. I remember those large grey masses of granite for hill slopes surrounding the valley that did make quite an oppressive sight, especially near the end of the long winter-to-summer term. As Naidu Sir spoke, his demeanour changed from the soft-spoken and mellowed to his old drillmaster form, minus the whistle – "Come on, boys! this way!" leading us up the hill and down by different routes. We all had thoughts at the back of our minds on giving something for what we took of Rishi Valley with us. Perhaps this setting triggered off the subsequent concrete steps.

Walking away from the crowd in small groups for a while, a 'whispering conference' started. It became a serious discussion later, over the evening. Ramdass, Shiavax and Gowri initiated a suggestion vetted by the rest of us, that something be done for these devoted men and women who have given their lives for the quality of all our lives. Most staffers would move to more expensive places on retirement, unless they left in their prime years for a more lucrative job. How about a pension trust fund? Another problem we found was that while teachers (and staff?) got free education for their children at school but their means were grossly inadequate for university education. So a trust fund was also mooted for assisting children of staff members with their university education. Yet another but inevitable question came up about the school's presence on the Internet. We felt that both the domain, its content and interactivity should be governed from Rishi Valley itself, given its fabulous computer facilities and archives by which richer content could be created and updated. The school could also have a channel of communication through the Internet. The existing sites could all be linked by an umbrella Website. We decided to take this up with the school administration.

Returning by sun-down, we found the Asthachal place deserted, its observance discontinued for a variety of reasons. We however observed our own Asthachal, sitting at the same place for few minutes.

A splendid dinner was laid out for us all by the all the senior faculty, Aruna's active participation and staff behind the Old Guest House which is now Krishnamurti Study Centre. And we had worked up an appetite for it from all the walking and talking! Using Shivanand as our spokesman, we put fourth the suggestions to Dr Shirali, Dr Kumaraswami and Mr Shailendran, Mr Alope Mathur and others. They were open to the gist of all we had to say, but it seems some of our concerns were addressed during Krishnaji's time. A pension fund was already in existence. As for the Websites, it was considered wise to take advantage of the existing ones. Once Rishi Valley would get the promised Internet connectivity as a number of villages in AP have got, some support to the existing ones and appropriate links could be thought of. They were however more open to the formation of a trust for financial assistance to the children of staff pursuing higher studies. We suggested that a trust called Rishi Valley Alumni Initiative would be formed, which would be administered from the campus and a bank account for this would be opened there. Aruna was made the alumni's' envoy, to handle this work at the RV end.

We began 2nd October with a morning walk to our Grand Canyon, starting before daybreak, to see students with their notebooks carrying out all manner of nature study excercises and jotting down a variety of observations. Obviously the academic workload is higher than in our time, but so seemed the motivation level. And the 10th and 12th students who we met seemed any day more innocent than the precautious, often pretentious, wily and cynical city breed

A special assembly was convened for our benefit. Chants & Songs book in hand, we joined Narayana Narayana, Devaraja Sevyamana, Aygiri Nandni, Sundara sheetal samir suhaani and Raghu Jhandala Bhajana in full throttle and litle appaswaram - no scolding by Meenakshi Akka this time! One could not help remembering those 'general assemblies': writing KICK ME or packing punches on backs of those in the front benches; either keeping a stony silence or blasting the auditorium out of tune; variations like Gopi has a lorry; my silent mischief partners, Rajeev Yadav and V Ganapathy next to me on the same long bench. Having only just heard of Rajeev's sad life and fatal accident some three years ago and remembering others like Vishalakshi Akka, Dr Iyer, Raju Mama and others who would be very much part of all programmes in the auditorium - all of whom are no more, I had to battle for control of my emotions. Slowly looking around, I saw others in the same boat too and that felt comforting. An electric silence followed. Remembering our imitations of Dr Balasundaram, Dr Iyer and Mr Venks announce the week-end entertainment programme at the end of the assembly lightened the mood a little.

Later in the morning one more classmate joined us - Suvarnarekha and her husband Naresh. They were only able to spare one day, being busy doctors in Bangalore.

Conducted by Naidu Sir again, we walked through the Estate, under the Banyan Tree, past the Dairy, Mallibhavi Well, Krishna Well, down the long 35 ft wide bund built to divert the Rishi River and past the lake-sized percolation tank as well as one of the many check dams. This aspect of watershed development and conservation work has succeeded in bringing back birds like the Yellow-throated Bulbul to the Valley. It has been documented in detail by the Institute of Bird studies and Natural History in its publication Rishi Valley: Experiment in Ecological Regeneration and Environmental Education. A noted travel and foreign affairs writer Robert D Kaplan has devoted an entire chapter to this work, Rishi Valley and Human Ingenuity in his book The Ends of the Earth: A Journey at the Dawn of the 21st Century. We traversed the orchards - papayas, bananas, coconuts, guavas - this time with full sanction to 'raid' any tree provided the fruit was ripe! One lot of tender coconuts was sent to the Guest House. We also saw the new Sericulture Centre which, going by Naidu Sir's track record, could put RV on the silk map! Another striking observation was that all fertiliser requirements were met by composting of all agricultural wastes while neem provided excellent non-toxic pesticide. All these techniques are disseminated for the local villages' benefit through the rural education programme.

Yet another experience was the Rural Education Centre, previously the Elementary School. We were driven there and to a 'Satellite School' by Mr Shailendran. The system and its functioning, difficult to explain this briefly, is the brainchild of Mr and Mrs YA Padmanabha Rao, who shifted there from Hyderabad nearly two decades ago. Adapting the concept of assignment cards for each student as in the Western countries, here children were given a host of imaginative assignments in the local language or dialect, relevant to their lives. The teacher would be a "facilitator" to guide the activity of a child making progress at his or her own pace and initiative. Aids were improvised there too, by the teachers. Letters cut out of rubber sheet, for example, so that their shape could be learned by their feel by children, especially those in first generation of literacy. Traditional leather puppets, Bombalatta acting out plays with a lesson, educative toys and games made out of locally available materials. The results are well proven, with a very low drop-out rate and highly increased literacy level. These schools have their own kitchen to provide a mid-day meal as well as play space. Students from RVS are also involved in a number of the activities of the REC school.

The above rural education system has been developed into a model. Teachers are also trained under this model at the REC and Satellite Schools have been started at about 30 villages within a 40-50 KM radius. Such schools are started on waste / fallow land provided by the village Panchayat. Development begins with planting of trees, flower and fruit-bearing plants; sinking of a borewell with partial assistance, construction of a functional structure appointment of the trained teacher and assistance in preparation of the educational material. Parents from the village are also encouraged to visit and participate, such as in serving food etc. At the Satellite school near Kurbalakota that we visited, a leather-puppet show was enacted by children. A parent had brought halwa on account of his daughter's birthday, which he distributed while also helping the staff serve lunch to the children. A Health Officer under this Centre (Kartik Kalyanraman, Tape - ISC '77 - AFMC Pune graduate who worked in the Air Force until earlier this year) takes a round of the REC and all Satellite Schools, providing free health care and counsel to each student and at a very nominal fee to others in the villages. One standard plaything at each center was a tree swing made from a used tyre and v-belts. Our own Mr SJ Vazifdar tested and adjudicated each as fit, even as he learnt by a rather hard way that one tyre was under-size for his girth and one v-belt too elastic for his weight!

The villages also looked stepped up - smooth paved roads, clean swept courtyards and lanes, neatly dressed folks and growing 'wet' crops, fruits and vegetables where dry crops were the norm. The countryside is sprinkled with ponds and rivulets, run-off being controlled by check dams and bunds. And trees line the village landscape too.

Late afternoon, Sathibai Akka hosted a tea party for us at Red House, she insisted on serving each one of us and was full of fuss, making us forget we ever grew up! And she seems to have a remarkable memory for all her 'children', enquiring after each of our classmates and siblings. The old Red House Papamma of our times (God knows the good lady's real name!) came specially from the village and was very moved to see everyone, more so with Anand, Shiavax, Ramdass, Shivanand and Gowri who had been in the Red and Blue Houses, under their care. A printout of the old class photo was also autographed by all of us and presented to Sathibai Akka.

Later that evening, being Saturday evening slated for a film in good tradition, the folk dancing session was preponed by 24 hours for our benefit - see the spoils of having your classmate teaching! Though the music evoked more nostalgia and motivation, this was perhaps the first reminder of age catching up. Right limb moving where the left should have. One forward step while everyone else step both ways - much to the amusement of the students. Overcoming cold feet, I would cautiously join a dance after brushing up the steps, by which time it would end. Our old New Hostel Housemaster, English teacher and cricket supervisor JP had arrived from Chennai earlier in the day. He insisted on having us over to his place for an after-dinner chat and desert. We went back to the guest house and chatted late to hone our ideas on the Initiative and to horse around till the wee hours.

3rd of October. The day to leave had already come. Again by daybreak, this time we had to finish an important mission of the re-union. Climbed to the base of Cave Rock, then backtracked and went up to Boat Rock, puffing like old steam engines, but strangely not tired. Took in the aerial view of the new-look Valley, recalling earlier expeditions. Campus under tree cover - no sign of a 600-strong establishment. Pucca houses in all the villages, some two-storeyed, a macadam road connecting them, as against mud huts in haphazard clusters and a dirt track meandering between. Electricity in the houses, streets, submersible pumps and borewells. More bunds and check dams. Telephone lines. And lush green fields where boulder-laden soil just permitted sparse cultivation. Cars, tractors, buses and a bulldozer all carrying people to begin another purposeful day, where all we had seen were few bullock carts picking their way along the meander of a subsistence-farmer's life.

We had a final discussion to tie up loose ends on the Initiative in the mid-morning Tea Break. To go ahead with a trust independent of the school's funds, whose initial focus would be on the earlier stated financial support to staff children. Other ideas could be proposed later. Unfortunately this kind of intention has been expressed by so many other alumni and forgotten. Few others have exploited this type of want-to-do feelings of the alumnus fraternity and made a PR gimmick or appealed for funds without their own contribution. (Whereas here a sizeable sum has already been set aside by at least three classmates, I now learn.) We felt that the best thing would be to identify the 'doable' and act on it. Like Aruna had done towards reviving some of the co-curricular activities that were once a tradition - folk dancing, the old chants and songs among them - in addition to her role as senior biology teacher. As we put the Initiative on the Internet we could share more ideas and identify areas of commitment. And so we concluded.

Ramkumar gave an excellent presentation of slides on the civic movement EXNORA that he presides. They have done exemplary work at Chennai and (recently at) Bangalore, addressing issues from waste management, recycling and cleaning of streets to preservation of mangroves and clean-up of water-bodies polluted by effluent disposal. The work had been commended and seen as a model by the World Bank and other UN organisations. Ramkumar had visited other countries to present their successfully proven concepts in civic improvement. He had overcome the diffidence of his school days and built up a successful legal practice. Apparently he never let others' jokes get the better of his sharp gaze, curious stares and his spirit of adventure. His interest in emergent technologies and outdoor activity continue to this day. Just my favourite sort of customer! Perhaps the most successful student of our batch in terms of the school's objectives.

I shall not describe the good-byes, drive to Bangalore, a ten-minute hello to Dr Balasundaram and Meenakshi Akka, then the journey by Udayan Express back to Mumbai.

On our way out of the school we stopped at Mr CR Hanumanta Rao's house, at the fringe of the 1st Village. The same serene expression, bright smile, nominally aged, with a beard. He spoke with fond remembrances of all of us and enquired after all siblings, relatives and other classmates, remembering each one's name and ISC year! He has retired, but carries out some translation work and is also an advisor to the RV organisation. Some people come to him for Sanskrit lessons. His son Babu (ISC'77) an engineer, is a senior executive in a computer training organisation, having previously put in ten years of service at ONGC and built this two-storeyed house with a most well-tended garden. We took leave from this perfect picture of a fruitful life and a continuing interest in it. And the much endeared old guard like him, Naidu Sir, Mishraji, Sathibai Akka and JP playing the role Robert Kaplan likened to granite columns holding the aerial roots of an ever-growing banyan tree. Support systems that bolster our alma mater against 'crashes and cataclysms' in its journey across generations. The familiar hillsides diminished as more and more road entered the line of sight. And Shivanand's Esteem glided on . . .

“Valley Re-Discovered” — a polished previously-written essay by the late Udit Chaudhuri on the 1972 batch's 1999 return trip; a potential centerpiece long-form piece.

ENTRY 29 OF 42

Being A Woman

Hari Sankaran (shared by Kartik Kalyanram) · 27 April 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Kartik Kalyanram Being A Woman.pdf · 7 pages

Kartik Kalyanram This evocative piece was written by my classmate Hari Sankaran

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty Nice. A personal story, and data from around the world, interwoven so well 👍

Harsha Should be compulsory reading in every school.

Harsha How is Hari?

Uday Bajekal Really eloquently written and thoughtful. Thanks Kartik.

wiki sardesai Absolutely brilliant and unfortunately true 👍 Well done ✅

Manisha Arora Beautifully written, thoughtfully woven with sensitivity, understanding and compassion. Sad yet undeniably true.

Dechu Kuppanda Beautifully written, so well captured. One step at a time, we are finally walking the right way. I loved the writing style too. I also have very fond memories of Hari and his big laughter.

Sathya Gourisankar I also enjoyed the nice write-up, conveying the ground realities and articulating the message in such a simple and clear, no-frills manner!

“Being A Woman” — an alumni-authored essay the community itself flagged as exceptional (attached PDF). Strong writing, though it contains no RV-specific content.

Bull Rao and the Well

Harsha · 17 December 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

One of my dear classmates, Venkataramana Rao, got tossed into a well by a protective mother while photographing her calf. He came back to the hostel dripping wet with a big grin on his face, far more concerned about how well the photo turned out than his soaked camera or himself. That same dark room did develop the photo. The calf was there in all its glory and Bull Rao went on to become a wonderful reporter.

Classmate “Bull Rao” tossed into a well by a protective mother cow while photographing her calf, returning soaked but grinning, worried only about the photo. He became a reporter.

The Pavilion

B R Venkatesh, Dechu Kuppanda, Sathya Gourisankar, Harsha · 12 July 2026 – 13 July 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

B R Venkatesh *'The Pavillion'*

That has witnessed many victories and losses on the A field of Cricket matches, football matches, annual sports, over several decades, with spectators cheering the home team. The juice table, the score board, OMG how time flies....

Ananth IRAS PFA Con SR So many memories... 🥺

Dechu Kuppanda It was so nostalgic reading the messages and seeing these beautiful photos. Amazing. Thank you.

Sathya Gourisankar This new pavilion was built during our times in late sixties or early seventies. Prior to this, the old iconic pavilion with a cute dressing equipment room stood also alongside a tree which was very dear to many of us with lot of history. What seems common to both these pavilions and much of RV is the constant presence of a beloved tree, that has stood witness to all the victories, losses and moments of great bonding as well as lessons learned through sports events at RV! Such nice memories come flooding from this pic!

K Ramesh There was this lovely cement slide behind the old pavilion .

Uday Bajekal Shining concrete after years of use! I remember it well.

K Ramesh Yes, shiny slide indeed.

Prasanna M Nlr Played "Slide Komba" on it . "TreeKomba" on nearby trees & "BallKomba (?)"" on/in the Moonlight Dinner quadrangle behind RedH , BlueH & MalliH

Prasanna M Nlr KothiKomba , not TreeKomba .

S Thomas Old pavillion 🙌

S Thomas Recycling old pics 😊

Prasanna M Nlr Any idea of which year ?

Shankar S.V Sunil, kindly correct me if iam wrong. Sharada Vishwanath sliding down. Kothi Ram trying to push with one leg. Behind him is Prasanna, Satyanarayan Nanda, Giridhar Mani, Shivakumar from Kandukur and possibly Jyothi Subrahmanyam.

Prasanna M Nlr Could well be , Shankar . I am unable to imagine us to be so emancipated as being so bi-gender those times . Maybe it is Breddy & Raj Iyer . Incorrect ?

Nagi Narayanan I remember sitting on those steps and watching famous cricketer Kirmani, play with his team against our school boys !!

Once when I got a chance to meet him I told him that I had been a student of RV when he played there.

He was very surprised and happy 😊👍

B R Venkatesh Kirmani comes to me to sort out his health issues.

In 1973 he had come with another stalwart G R Vishwanath.

A good match but the Bangalore team won.

The pitch had COIR carpets and only one side bowling back then.

Those good old days

B R Venkatesh Corridors of learning was always abuzz with colourful students chit chatting during breaks after the 40 min of class.

Sathya Gourisankar Reminds me of the teaching legends of our times with whom we had such good conversations in the corridors. In fact, the corridor conversations were often more valuable than the class room instruction where teachers shared so much of their insights going beyond mere subject matter! I remember distinctly how some of our teachers would emerge out of the staff room, walking into our class room for their period, one of them very notable was our English teacher, Prasad Sir, he would carry the books of "To Kill A Mocking Bird," "Grapes of Wrath," or "Julius Ceasar," in his hands holding them close to his nose as if he was smelling them and walk deliberately to the class room! Then, there was our Principal, Dr. Balasundaram, always walking at brisk pace and keeping an eye on all things happening around him. Prasad Sir told me one day he was walking into the classroom just one minute late when Dr. B asked him, "Prasad, why are you late for your class?" Prasad sir said that was the last day in his career that he ever late even by a minute for any of his classes where he taught across locations for so many years later!

Harsha What the stones say we seldom hear, memories etched to a polish

A pavilion photo prompting reflection on the witness-tree, a funny anecdote about Prasad Sir and Dr. B's exacting punctuality, and Harsha's original poem about old stones holding memory.

M.L. Vasanta Kumari at RV

Dechu Kuppanda, Mahesh, Harsha · 4 April 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Sathya Gourisankar Posting this nice article about M.S. and IITM, I received from my alma mater, IIT Madras alum news. I am posting this because I know of many music lovers from RV who will enjoy reading this which talks about not only the great musical talent of M.S. but also the generosity of herself and her husband, Mr. Sadasivam. There is strong RV and K connection to M.S. family not only due to their family members who studied there (my senior Kannan of 1965 batch, my classmate A.V. Rajagopal of 1972, two I am aware of) but also of her close friendship with Visalakshi Akka (wife of Dr. B, Principal of RV). In fact, in my time, on many an occasion, K used to arrive in RV in M.S.'s car from Chennai. Therefore, I am claiming exemption from any charge of posting non-RV, non-K related news!!!! https://joyofgiving.alumni.iitm.ac.in/alma-matters/heritage-center/the-nightingale-visits-iit-madras?utm_campaign=7289605-Alma%20Matter%20Newsletter&utm_medium=email&_hsenc=p2ANqtz-9fic9FMgem3H-txG1u4dnzg1wr0Jx7UqINCHgTBxqN2Wib2DA2vGkB5-1YCQu0_IePy1htfOUPsOMPT2shvmxpikAiqg&_hsmi=26043157&utm_content=26043157&utm_source=hs_email

Dechu Kuppanda While batches senior to us think fondly of MS Subalakshmi, our batches from the late 70s have very fond memories of ML Vasanta Kumari.

One of my seniors Sharmila - her dad was connected to all the great performances of that time. He brought many of them to school to perform. Some multiple times. We had the pleasure of watching Pandit Shivkumar Sharma, Ustad Zakir Hussain and many such great artists.

One time ML Vasanta Kumari and Palghat Mani Iyer came to perform. After that both of them came to live in RV. MLV was the sweetest most approachable person. You would never know she was so famous. She always helped us with our music and dance performances with her guidance.

Personally, I only realized how big a performer she was when, one time when helping finalizing sarees for a ballet she wanted one of the dancers to wear her saree. She sent me to her house to bring the saree. I still remember looking at her extensive collection of kanchipuram sarees and the realization dawning on me, that she was really famous. She had enough to fill a small shop. Yet, she was so simple in person.

Mahesh Yes Sharmila Hemady

Mahesh Hariprasad chaurasia, Pandit Jasraj

Harsha We had that very unique advantage of watching and listening to performance by some of the greatest in music and dance with no bias. Pure enjoyment of the art and the ability to interact with such great people with the innocence of childhood unfettered by awe, just driven by curiosity. To us they were just "Akkas" and "Sirs". Truly amazing.

Growing up around famous musician ML Vasanta Kumari at RV, capped by Harsha's beautiful line about watching greats "with the innocence of childhood unfettered by awe."

There Is No Padmashree Here

Anita Reddy · 26 June 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

In all humility, and as you mention this, I had a big surprise call one evening in January 2010. I was working at home with my team mate bhagya, and we were feverishly finishing some project documents. There was a call from Delhi and they spoke in hindi which I understand fairly well but that day I didn't. 😊 It was on my landline. I answered three times and put the phone down saying there is no padmashree (a person i thought) here. Finally I told bhagya there is some wrong number asking for padmashree. She took the phone and when she spoke she got someone to come online who knew English. And he told me to my total shock, that the call was from Rashtrapathi Bhavan, and would I accept the Padmashree from the president. As there was zero build up to that moment like no applications, no conversations and absolutely no aspirations for such recognitions , (I never apply for awards for obvious reasons plus I am an RVite to the core after all 😊) I most humbly told the gentleman that this call belongs to the people I worked with and for, and so I bow to the nation if it is recognizing the issues of the poor in our country. This is exactly how the padmashree was given to me on April 1st(note the date 😊) of 2011 for the year 2010. I recollect my father Dwaraknath Reddys words then* and he was as surprised too) that when you do something silently it gets noticed somewhere. What's important is you continue working silently. I still do. And on that day I said in the interviews that RVS had a big influence on me and I reiterate in this conversation (as sunil mentioned the award and i just saw rohits message too) that I dedicate it to the people struggling and winning their rights as much as to all of the RVS family that has come alive with this Alumni group and dialogues. 🙏🙏

Hanging up three times on the call informing her of her Padma Shri ("there is no padmashree here"), then dedicating the honor to the RVS family. Self-effacing and warm.

The Party Buses Home

Sathya Gourisankar and others · 21 May 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Aunohita There is also the option of bus-ing it to R.V. which would really take us right back to school time and the various 'parties' as our respective groups were known as! As part of a very small Delhi party I was always part of the Madras party bus (so we could catch the train in Madras central for all of my 8 plus years) but am all ready to jump ship (bus) to the Bangalore party now!

Vinayak (Jayant) Joshi Bombay party was the largest in my time. Going to Cudapha by bus having lunch at Ramdases place and boarding the train for Mumbai.

B R Venkatesh The school uses local buses to send kids home. Eg. JNR bus for RV to BLR and vice versa. 50 seater regular bus.

Prasanna M Nlr Gudur Party of about 15 used to go by ordinary bus.

Sathya Gourisankar In our time, when the different party buses from cities arrive in RV, our Principal Dr. B and Vice Principal Dr. Iyer and other teachers would be waiting for hours to receive the students in front of the senior girl's house — those were days pre-cell phones so no way to know precise arrival times! What dedication of those great teachers of RV who treated us as their own kids and took so much care of us! Now, as alums, if we go by buses, one person I can visualize receiving us warmly will be the ageless, timeless one and only one Gopal of the guest house!

Shankar S.V A small trivia which may interest you. A very sprightly young teacher would climb up to boat rock and keep watch early in the morning and as soon as the 1st bus turned into the mouth of the valley, he would blow a tune on his bugle, which could be heard very well all over the campus. That was a signal that the Principal and resident teachers could assemble in front of Green house to receive the various parties. Thought it may be of interest for those who never knew this part.

Sathya Gourisankar Yes Shankar, your dear Father and our dear Teacher, Venks Sir, did that and many more such wondrous things for us all those days! Who can forget them? Grateful for your sharing it.

overflow.md's stated source lines (4567–4568) and date (23/01/2026) for this item hold an unrelated Alumni-meet registration notice. The correct thread was located at alumni lines ≈7282–7328, dated 21–22/05/2026, and is reproduced above.

How the school moved children home before mobile phones: city-grouped buses ("Madras party"), Dr. B and Dr. Iyer waiting to see every child safely off, escort-teachers riding the trains.

A Rahul Dravid Moment

Sathya Gourisankar and Shankar S.V. · 22 May 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Sathya Gourisankar G.R. Vishwanath, Syed Kirmani and others belonging to Jawahar Union Cricket Club in Bangalore, visited RV for Cricket match in 1972. GRV then was a super star of Indian Cricket. He got drunk the previous night in school guest house (as he always used to), next day he scored 42, got out caught by Shankar in first slip of the bowling of Bankim Sutaria. Shankar, please confirm this detail.

S Thomas Probably, I forget the details.

Sathya Gourisankar The school arranged a dance program in the auditorium for the Bangalore team of GRV and others, the night before the match. Venks Sir knew many of them personally and talked to them in Kannada, like the brother of V.V. Subramanyam, former India Cricketer and captain of then Mysore state team, brother of Budi Kunderan who was former wicket keeper for India, etc who were in that team with GRV and Kirmani. My classmate Prabhakar Reddy excelled in that match and drew high praise from both GRV and Kirmani for his pace bowling with late swing!

S Thomas I think Venks Sir's serious cricket happened in Mysore.

Shankar S.V Absolutely the best memories in my cricketing life Sathya. Thanks for bringing it up. Yes, the great GRV in slips of the bowling of Bankim Sutaria and later on Kirmani at mid on of a towering shot. They are still fresh in memory. Ofcourse, Jawahar sports club were too good and I swear I just couldn't read Arun Kumar's googlies at all.

Later I recollect we were all Seated at the place where we had moonlight dinners and I remember asking Kirmani how they faced up to the deadly West Indian pace attack. He simply joked " Bas Allah ka naam leke bat ghumate the, lag gaya to lag gaya "

Also, before the catch of GRV I witnessed one of his famous square cuts from second slip. Before I could blink, the ball had reached the boundary. I was really spellbound.

Fabulous memories. Thanks Sathya for rekindling them.

Sathya Gourisankar Thank you Shankar for validating the memory recall of a rising "septuagenarian!" I now feel more confident I can trust my memory of long ago events and dish it out as needed to audiences without worrying about my credibility!!! On a personal note, do you remember us both you playing in a match against the strong SV university team in Tirupati which we drew with my match saving knock of 26 along with partnership for the ninth wicket with Shivakumar and after I got out, you came in as last batsman, played out the remaining overs and saved a big match for us? Venks Sir and our NIS coach of those days, Mr. S.L.Rao were in our team and Mr. Shiva Sankaraiya was their PE coach and played in their team in our match of 1971 and four years later, when I watched the India West Indies test match live in Chepauk in 1975, that same Sivasankariah was the umpire who made a grossly unfair decision to give Pataudi out LBW to Andy Roberts which I watched with dismay as the ball wrapped him on the pads well outside the off stump on his back foot defence!

Harikiran Reddy The same Jawahar Cricket Club revisited RV to play during 1981/82. Amongst them were Karnataka Ranji players Srinivas Prasad, Sadanand Viswanath and a few other Karnataka players. We did lose against them. Srinivas Prasad scored heavily on that day.

Shankar S.V Oh! What a lovely memory Sathya. It was a great match and I recall it very well. Sivasankariah tried his level best and also their main bowler Subbuswami to no avail. I somehow managed bat till the end with Ashok Shenoy.

Also do you recollect how we slept at the SV university stadium in the night. It was windy and lot of mosquitoes. We used to walk down to Esvee restaurant for lunch and dinner. I particularly remember them blaring a Hindi song " jeevan hai ek Sapna " all the time.

Gautam Mahmood Anyone remember when the team from Kolar Gold Fields visited? I think they played two matches ?

I remember it was a tie and they celebrated - really friendly crowd.

Gautam Mahmood Or was it Hindupur?

Sathya Gourisankar Shankar, Yes I remember the Esvee restaurant where we ate Masala Dosa and the sleeping. I will narrate this one more thing and stop as I do not want our friends on the group to be put off by old memories of us few. In that match, SV univ had scored 140 for four or so and declared. We started badly, were tottering at 60 or so with eight wickets down when I was batting and Shivakumar joined me. Per Cricketing jargon, we were "staring down the barrel" with no hope. I recall Sivasankariah, the tall, hefty Man, standing menacingly close to tiny me at silly mid off and yelling all kind of bad words at his fielders and bowlers in Telugu, who were trying to get Siva and me out to wrap up the match. Somehow, after surviving some tense moments with intimidatory bowling cum harsh sledging as well from Sankariah, Siva and I settled into a nice partnership, grew in confidence and took the score to about 100 for eight but more importantly, consumed time to generate hopes for an honorable draw and deny that strong team a victory. Now, Sankariah was at his raging best fury with his team, screaming loudly as us two kids started to defy them stubbornly. In fact, his outbursts helped us both to concentrate harder and we become more determined to save the match. Then came the bowling change when their super fast bowler Akkaraju charged in with the old ball, reverse swung perhaps and got the faintest edge of my bat to get me caught at first slip. As I walked back to the pavilion to a standing ovation, you came out to bat and I told you to just hang in there for only few more overs remaining to draw the match. You went and did exactly that, presenting a dead defence to all they threw at you and ensured a triumph for our team to draw against a mighty univ team with so many stars plus that foul mouthed Sankariah whose screaming and sledging I can recall to this day fifty five years later! In cricketing terms, you showed character and pluck to save the day for us, the atmosphere in the stadium where our team was watching those last few overs was tense and nail biting, including the reaction of your Father who had to contend with his emotions both as team mate and parent, a tough combination!

Harikiran Reddy Such lovely memories Sathya. 1982/83 we played under the captaincy of your brother Karthik for the RVS team. 😊

Sathya Gourisankar Thks Hari. Karthick has mentioned often about you!

S Thomas I remember Shivashankariah (celebrated Physical Director of SV Univ) whacking sixes over the neem tree into B Field (later called the hockey field).

S Thomas That was the year some of us old students from all over came to RV to play a match - Anantaram 1974, New Ram(krishna) 1975, Hariram Achanta 1979, Chellam 1979 and a few others.

Sathya Gourisankar Surprised RV tolerated him! Much as his batting was explosive, his tongue was a weapon of mass destruction!

Sathya Gourisankar I have tough memories of him because he was telling his bowlers to knock me down with bouncers and even hit me, imagine me five foot, lanky kid having to face such fiery bowling of univ and AP junior state players on top of hearing this Man within hand shaking distance threatening to blow me apart! Probably my toughest experience of terrorist type bullying I have encountered, now I feel quite proud I did not bat an eye lid or pay heed to him but just focused on saving the day for my team!

Prasanna M Nlr Or , self-protection , team be damned .

Usha K Self protection yes, only for saving the day for the team.

Ram R You have a flair for telling a story, Satya. Make it come alive ! Glad to have spent some years with you as a classmate. 😊

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty This, I remember. He, ML Jaismha, sat with us kids in the makeshift pavilion (between the cricket and hockey grounds). Spic and span in whites, that too full sleeve swan white shirt , top button open , collar up, salt and pepper hair and dark Aviator glasses... the whole crowd of children around him were in awe of him as he talked to us all about Sunil Gavaskar for some reason ...

But really, GR Vishwanath played in RV ? That would have been something for those who saw him there....

Sathya Gourisankar Yes Rohit, Sunil Gavaskar has also written how he used to adore and admire MLJ, those days younger people would try to bowl like him with the curved run up and dragged foot action, dress like him, gesture like him, etc. He was a hero on many fronts on and off the field for the youngsters of those times. Later, he was admired for his astute captaincy skills, commentary skills and insights on the game!

Sathya Gourisankar RVL, Thank you for the observation. As your classmate, I was never in the story telling mode while at RV. I became a bit of a story narrator only in the last ten years of my professional career when I transitioned from industry and had the opportunity as Professor to mentor young careers for leadership roles in the medical device industries, for which I think I subconsciously somehow adopted a story telling theme (with real world stories of my failures and successes in my industry career) for my lectures and discussions, honed my skills there and now get often told by folks that I am a story teller! Yes, I will accept that label and only hope to improve on that front to make sure my stories are entirely non-fictional, credible recollections, devoid of unpleasantness of any kind and uplifting in however small a measure as possible! I hold many fond memories of my dear classmates and peers like you at RV who have enriched my life immeasurably in my years there.

Sathya Gourisankar That day and inning perhaps, I became transformed into a Rahul Dravid, my role model hero for his selfless dedication to team cause and being a true team player! Just one off event in my case, I cannot claim any kind of resemblance to the all time great Dravid for his life time achievements!

Ram R Keep them coming. Enriches our memories too 😊

A gripping match-saving cricket partnership against SV University despite sledging — Sathya's "Rahul Dravid moment" — corroborated and praised by the group ("you have a flair for telling a story").

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Sports and Rishi Valley — A Historical Perspective

Sunil Thomas (S Thomas) · 29 June 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp — PDF attachment (00007947-DOC-20250326-WA0010.pdf)

Every year, for seventeen years, I would get my copy of the Journal of the Krishnamurti Schools and read it from cover to cover. The articles would help re-evaluate myself as a teacher each time. I would encounter the first page of the Journal where the several dimensions of education are listed, philosophy, psychology, classroom experience... to contemporary issues. More recently I began to wonder where or how sports would fit into this list. As a student, alumnus and staff, I have been actively involved with and been a keen observer of sports in Rishi Valley School for almost 50 years – hence my curiosity. After all, most of our children spend on an average thirteen hours a week engaged in sport. It always intrigued me as to how it survived eight decades of institutionalised sanction in a form that is in very little variance with that practiced outside the circle of Krishnamurti Schools. Here was an activity that formed an important part of boarding school life in Rishi Valley, and yet had the potential to undermine what are thought to be some of Krishna-ji's key principles of education. In this time, sports, with all its associated failings, and disappointments, did not fall victim to dogmatic or narrow interpretations of the words 'comparison' and 'competition'.

In 1961, students, colleagues and close friends of G. V. Subba Rao came together to pay homage and to subsequently compile a biographical record of his life and achievements in the field of education. The book, "Remembering G. V. Subba Rao" has been extensively referenced for a historical perspective covering the 1930s and 40s.

Dr Radhika Herzberger's essay "Multigrade Instruction at Rishi Valley and Neel Bagh: Philosophical and Historical Perspectives", has also been referred to quite extensively, to help throw light on Rishi Valley's educational philosophy during the 1950's. A lot of the observations made in the essay have their origins in notes made by F.G Pearce, the Principal of Rishi Valley School during this period.

A third source of information came from alumni and teachers of the School from the 1950s to 1970s. These individuals felt compelled to document their memoirs of a period they remembered with nostalgia and fondness.

All these sources provided insights into how the strong influence of a small number of successive individuals ensured a surprising degree of continuity to the way sports has been played and implemented in Rishi Valley. This continuity was ensured during a time spanning five decades when Krishna-ji's educational philosophy seemed to be understood differently with each change in administration.

The first such individual was G. V. Subba Rao whose involvement and commitment to sport began much before he headed the School in Rishi Valley. He moved from Madras in 1916 to join The Theosophical College in Madanapalle where he taught Economics by day and promoted sports like hockey, football and cricket in the evenings. Tennis and badminton were already established by then, but G. V. Subba Rao felt that field games like hockey, football and cricket, for which he had a special liking, had to be introduced to provide more physical exercise. Fallow agricultural fields were converted into playing grounds to accommodate these newly introduced sports. He involved the students in preparing and marking the fields, and ensured that about 500 out of the 800 students of the Institution were active on the fields every evening.

Later in 1918, Annie Besant formed the Society for the Promotion of National Education, and asked G. V. Subba Rao to return and start the National Theosophical School at Teynampet, Madras. There was an emphasis on the "open air" and outdoors at this school, where games, scouting, nature study, gardening, and craft formed part of the day's timetable. To keep the boys fit, a retired military Havildar would wake up the senior children and younger staff at 5 A.M for physical training exercises. In June 1920, the National Theosophical School shifted to Guindy, Adyar, where G. V. Subba Rao along with his teaching assignment, was given the duties of a games teacher. Any assignment from Annie Besant was considered sacred and the "staff put their heart and soul into the task with a deep sense of dedication".

G V Subba Rao would personally coach the senior teams in turn, daily. The School hockey team held the District Championship for many years. The team was much sought after to play with, by teams from Madras Medical College, Doveton School-Vepery, St. Bede's etc. Many students were invited to play for club teams like the Madras United Club and the Mylapore Recreational Club. The school clearly had one of the best hockey teams in the city.

Similarly, cricket was also played with enthusiasm. Weekends were spent for longer cricket games. The students were coached by staff and members of the Theosophical Society who had played the game earlier for Central Hindu School and College, Varanasi (governed by BHU). Friendly matches were regularly played against Guindy Engineering College and a few clubs in Madras. Mr H.C Buck, an American college sports coach and physical education instructor, took a special interest in associating with the Guindy School. He later went on to establish the YMCA College of Physical Education at Saidapet, Madras. C. B. Reddy, the Physical Director at The School, KFI and Rishi Valley School did his Physical Education training at this institution.

By one account, in 1931, as part of the exodus to Rishi Valley, only 93 students opted to make the move. By another account, not more than 35 seem to have finally made the move. For ten years Rishi Valley flourished under G. V. Subba Rao's stewardship. His biographers recall that wherever G. V. Subba Rao worked in an administrative capacity, he made games compulsory for all boys and girls of all ages and provided them with the necessary equipment and playground facilities. The biographers also suggest that he believed games provided desirable sportsmanship qualities and good health in all students. Education, according to him, did not come only from books. He believed that all experience can be converted into education. Hence, he had no objection to grant permission to the boys to play cricket matches on a working day if the weather was fine. The only condition he laid down was that all students must be engaged outdoors, either as players, scorers, umpires, or at least as spectators.

Cricket became the 'Game of the Valley', just as hockey was the game at Guindy, Adyar. Athletic meets had become an annual feature by then and prize distribution did not form part of the tradition. Much like today, the year-end filled up with extra sports and games activities. The intra-team, intra-house matches in cricket, hockey and football gradually evolved into a very comprehensive and widening activity involving the whole school, "including old students who gravitated happily to their happy home in the Valley".

G. V. Subba Rao believed in a non-competitive society, one in which co-operation more than competition played its part. If at all there was to be any competition, it should be in the nature of self-competition in which everyone tried to beat his or her own previous record. He seems to have recognised the inevitability of the evil effects of competition creeping in, but put in measures to minimise it by engaging students of similar ability and skills, some kind of competition among equals.

Certain sporting principles seem to have been established by this time. One was meant to play a game in a way that was enjoyable, and for keeping the body fit (thought necessary for a good and functioning mind). Games provided learning situations, much like those that emerged in classrooms. Sport and many other activities were not considered extra-curricular, but more co-curricular in nature. Opportunities in teamwork presented themselves more regularly while playing sports than in academic contexts. Other similar opportunities arose during performances, tree planting, litter picking and land care. In such activities, children developed the ability to be aware and attentive, applying their mind to the immediate. While playing sport, children were encouraged to be fair and not to harbour any bitterness, but to be empathetic and appreciative of each other. The ability to cope with setbacks was developed in children both in class and on the field. Children learnt to cope with and possibly eliminate stress, contradictions and conflict. However, like in all other contexts, these principles could be put to practice only with effective mentoring and under the watchful eye of teachers, in the absence of which the evils of competing against each other could rear their head.

After G. V. Subba Rao's time, the 1940s saw a ten-year period where Rishi Valley School continued under a succession of principals or headmasters. In 1948 Krishna-ji once again formulated his aims for Rishi Valley School, some of which stated that – 'There will be no fixed authority and no acknowledged leaders. The fundamentals are co-operation, equality and self-sufficiency'. F. Gordon Pearce, deeply moved by such a challenge, was willing to consider the possibility of working in an educational institution based on Krishna-ji's vision.

F. G. Pearce was a seasoned educator with substantial experience in the Indian educational system. His work with the organization of Indian Public Schools, and with the Indian Boy Scouts, was known throughout India and Sri Lanka. He had been the Principal of the Scindia School in Gwalior and, later, was the Director General of Education for the State of Gwalior; between 1925 and 1926 he was a prominent figure on the teaching faculty at Holkar College, Indore. Earlier, he was brought by Annie Besant from Ceylon (Sri Lanka) to build up the Indian Boy Scouts Movement. G. V. Subba Rao had earlier accepted in principle, activities associated with the Scouts Movement as being helpful in the development of the child as a well-integrated, intelligent member of society. He ensured that all the essential disciplines that these activities contributed to, were incorporated into the life at School in the 1930s. S. Venkatachalam who taught in Rishi Valley for close to 20 years, recalls in his memoirs, that, for reasons he did not explain, scouting was not formalised at School.

F. G. Pearce was eager to experiment with the novel educational philosophy. The Foundation that ran the School called itself 'The Foundation for New Education'. When Rishi Valley reopened on July 17th, 1950 with Gordon Pearce as principal there were fifteen students. With the help of some outstanding teachers, among them David Horsburgh, Sardar Mohammed, G. Narayan and Mahalakshmy, F. G Pearce attempted to draw his staff voluntarily into a cohesive culture, united in spirit of enquiry and dedicated wholly to the wellbeing of students, in a manner that sought to circumvent the imposition of authority.

Krishna-ji was a radical thinker who held that the aim of education was not to prepare students to become cogs in society's wheel, but to create a new world. He challenged his teachers to enter the rough and tumble of their own and their students' lives to create an educational system which was new. Teachers were meant to take Krishna-ji's central perception further with no short cuts to the continuing awareness he sought to awaken in his audiences. He informed his teachers that all systems and methods were destructive and that an approach needs to be maintained which is pliable and alive, which will help to deal with the student. In Krishna-ji's analysis, societal forces imbed themselves in individuals and find expression through emotions such as envy. He observed that comparison breeds envy, and that the whole of society is based on that structure of envy and acquisitiveness. He also observed that in our daily life, we are all the time comparing, and comparison of any kind is insulting to human dignity.

Krishnamurti held that a good school should have teachers who are 'capable of understanding freedom and helping the child to grow to its full freedom.' The underlying assumption here is that individuals, both teachers and students who remain anchored in petty emotions are not free. In bondage to their own pettiness, they will collectively create a school with teachers and students who willingly fit into a corrupt society.

In keeping with the ethos nurtured by G. V. Subba Rao and Krishna-ji's critique of regimented schooling, F. G. Pearce's school continued to disregard paraphernalia that marked successful schooling in modern India, like end-of-term examinations, competitive rankings, prizes, monitors, head boys and head girls, uniforms etc. Classes were organised such that students of different ages but of similar competency levels sat in the same room (a concept commonly borrowed for building teams in sports), whereby each student could move at his or her own pace through a subject mapped by teachers, with the help of multiple books. He did not think that tests were necessarily harmful. He looked at tests as necessary so that the child's progress may be assessed by the teacher and by the child himself. However, he was quick to admit that 'within the system of class-instruction, tests almost inevitably become competitive, and lead to a struggle for gaining marks and for rivalling others.' This is an issue the School grapples with even today.

An extract from a book written by a student, Raghunath (Ravi) Natu titled "Delightful Days at Rishi Valley", best describes the atmosphere prevalent in Rishi Valley School between 1955 and 1959.

"RV was going through a spell of experimentation. Princey (Principal) felt that to encourage competition in the early years robbed children of their creativity and spontaneity. Hence junior classes were not graded by number; instead they were named after constellations – Rohini, Shalini, etc. Classes were held in the classrooms and more often under trees and open places. No concept of homework existed. Yes, there was occasionally a tutorial period, generally in the evening. But this was more to acquire general knowledge through scanning encyclopaedias and other informative books in the library. Life was easy going. Most often we were left to ourselves, learning through games and sports, through PT and carpentry, in cookery and needlework classes, and finally by just lazing around with no particular objective other than to watch the world go by. These were halcyon years and such informal processes were subtly moulding these youngsters to learn about living life on their terms, unfettered and free, the way childhood was meant to be."

Another student from this period recalls "I was my own judge. I was my own competitor and got to enjoy what I was doing without expecting a reward. It did not matter if someone else was better or worse. There was no rivalry or jealousy. I just had to try and excel! Sport was clean and we indulged in a lot of adventure on our own...."

Under F. G. Pearce, sports flourished along the lines earlier established by G. V. Subba Rao. There is no evidence of any philosophical predicament or constraints put on sports based on Krishna-ji's newly formulated aims for the School. Rather, the presence of Sardar Mohemmed, G. Narayan and S. Venkatachalam only reinforced the School's sports tradition that ensured its continuity for the next 60 years. F. G. Pearce understood what Krishnamurti sought to convey – that the practice of awareness restrained the expression of ambition, competition, and jealousy. This understanding probably extended to sports, where sports itself did not have to fall victim in the quest to dissolve these negative expressions.

Sardar Mohemmed was a sportsman in the traditional sense who excelled in squash, tennis and cricket. He played Ranji Trophy cricket for the Holkar State, won squash championships in Calcutta and was a regular winner of all local tennis tournaments after he joined Rishi Valley School. G. Narayan played tennis with the likes of Ramanathan Krishnan at Loyola College – Madras. S. Venkatachalam was a fast bowler for his college and probably for the first time in the School's history, helped establish cricket, basketball and football coaching as part of the annual sports calendar. Ravi Venkatesan, a student from this time, was on the country's Davis Cup squad for a while.

Ravi Natu (Rishi Valley School, 1955-59) in his book, dedicates entire chapters to "Sports Day" and football (Goal!). The descriptions he so vividly provides, re-enforces the belief that nothing has fundamentally changed since then regarding athletic meets and 'external' matches with teams from Madanapalle and Chintamani. He recalls that "A healthy rivalry existed between Madanapalle XI and the RV football team, with the trophy changing hands frequently". The act of participating in tournaments was quite clearly not considered as unhealthy competition.

Although life in Rishi Valley School was close to idyllic for the students, fissures began to appear within the staff body regarding discipline, order and freedom leading to parental dissatisfaction. Despite Krishna-ji's best efforts to help his teacher body see that contrary beliefs need not pose insurmountable barriers to cooperation, that an alert mind and an inquiring spirit sees beyond fixed conclusions; and despite Pearce's own valiant attempt to be reasonable, he was unable to satisfy the contending attitudes and demands of teachers, parents and trustees. Finally, not able to achieve a balance between reasoned order and Krishna-ji's ideal of freedom, he resigned as Principal in 1958.

Dr Balasundaram, the next Principal, and Dr N. K. A. Iyer together took a personal interest in promoting sport, especially cricket and tennis. Dr. Balasundaram, S. Venkatachalam and Dr D. S. Babu played cricket with children on a regular basis, while Dr. N. K. A. Iyer was a seasoned cricket umpire. Staff and students were expected to witness all matches that were played on weekends. Teams from Kolar, Chintamani, Bangalore, Tirupati, Anantapur, Chittoor, Kalikiri and Madanapalle were regularly invited to play 'friendlies' with the School teams.

It was during Dr Balasundaram's tenure that professional NIS coaches trained in Patiala were invited to School for short periods during each term. By this time, cricket, football and basketball coaching became a permanent feature. Waseem-ul-Haq, the cricket coach, visited the School from 1972 to 2010. The School sent its cricket team regularly during the 1970s to play tournaments in Tirupati and Madanapalle. During the 1970s and 80s, many students represented Andhra Pradesh School teams in Cricket and Basketball. Basketball Schoolboy State selections were hosted on our grounds in 1973-74. Two students, Ravishankar Chellam and Noor Mohammed, eventually represented Andhra Pradesh in Ranji Trophy tournaments.

The pattern or system of sustaining various sports, developed during the 1960s and 1970s, and exists even today. Teachers like Dr D. S. Babu, Jayaprakash (JP), V. Srinivasan, and V. Prasad who played their respective games at the University and State levels, performed key roles in anchoring sports along with celebrated Physical Directors like N. S. Naidu and C. Balakrishna Reddy. Balaraj S, a professional tennis marker from the Cubbon courts in Bangalore, coached generations of students between 1967 and 2017. Jayant Tengshe (JT) anchored volleyball in a way that represented a student's 'true love for the game'.

Today, along the lines of G. V. Subba Rao's method, Rishi Valley School almost mandates that children up to the 8th standard play all the games based on term-wise and weekly schedules. For this age group, cricket, basketball and football coaching is built into the annual program. Between the 9th and 12th standards, children can make certain choices and are encouraged to take up any two sports in a serious manner. By a method of 'natural selection', children making the transition to Senior School are expected to understand their interests and abilities regarding sport, just as they make choices and specialise in subjects after the 10th standard.

Despite this long drawn-out process of 'natural selection', disappointments regarding exclusion and 'not making the team' are unfortunately inevitable in any team endeavour. This short coming is partly addressed by mentoring and expanding opportunities by offering a wide variety of sports and extended facilities. As comparison and competition are known to be fundamental features of habitual and unexamined thought, it is the aim of the educators to help students see things as they are.

PT and games keep a large percentage of students occupied with minimal supervision (at least for the senior students) for close to 2 hours a day. Lately, attempts to experiment with the equilibrium achieved over decades did not quite succeed, as the alternative activities could not be sustained in a meaningful way over time. Some of these initiatives for senior students included making games optional and diversifying the use of PT time into other activities that were quasi-monastic in nature. Strong objections raised by the students themselves led to a reversal, back to the old status quo. With a perceived increase in restlessness and attention related disorders among students, alternatives to sport are constantly being thought of (e.g. mindfulness, yoga, meditation), each of which have great merit if implemented in a sustainable manner with dedicated resources, by weaving them into life in a boarding school.

Krishna-ji has pointed out at one of his talks to the students (December 10, 1979), that the word 'compete' means striving together, moving towards something together. To those who are not aware of the etymology, the revelation is at the least, stunning. Can teachers identify situations where competing against each other can be transformed into situations where we seek, endeavour and learn together? He asked if the perception, significance and truth of the word 'compete' could be captured instantly. He explains that transformations are simple acts of bringing about some kind of order in daily life. Can sports in Rishi Valley embody a silent but determined effort to achieve an optimal balance between order and freedom, awareness and comparison, co-operation and competition?

References

1. "Remembering G V Subba Rao" – © G V Subba Rao Trust
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3. "Delightful Days at Rishi Valley" – by Raghunath (Ravi) Natu.
4. Memoirs of S.V. Venkatachalam (Venks Sir).
5. Golden Decade, Rishi Valley School – Published in 2012 by Lalasa Reddy, edited by Asha Williams, printed by Sujit Patwardhan

"Sports and Rishi Valley — A Historical Perspective," a six-page researched, personally-voiced history of RV sport across every principal, wrestling with how competition survived K's philosophy. Directly usable as a feature essay.

Suprabha on the Parallel Bars

Capt (Dr) Rohit Shetty · 30 June 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Since you all mentioned Suprabha, had written about her long ago. Just reposting it here :))

In school, my favourite ever senior wasn't on a hockey field, though I loved the game and one Prem, a super-senior who played with us, came close.

I was on the swing of the then recently constructed play park (that area with the Jungle Gym and the swings, between the football and the basketball courts) and I had this crazy compulsion of swinging higher and higher and then, when in full swing, flying off the swing and landing at a distance in front (I remember that Gadela would also do this, till his sis saw him once and "gave him properly"). So I was swinging away in a frenzied manner, trying to get the required thrust for take off, and this time it was a perfect one. As I soared through the air, suddenly my heart stopped! A girl appeared out of nowhere and was walking right across where I would be landing! I have no idea how I flew right above her head (scalp with a "boy-cut" I may add, as it was then known) and landed beyond her. She looked at me, confused, then looked at the empty creaking swing, and then back at me, this time wide-eyed, and said "whoa kid! Careful !!". Thats how I met.....

Suprabha Seshan. After that fright, I would meet her there in that place almost everyday. I was fond of the swings, but she came there for a different reason. She would get onto the parellal bars and do stuff that amazed me. She was a gymnast with talent. I've always, always felt, she was in the wrong school. She deserved to be professionally trained in gymnastics. In fact, as soon as she appeared everyday, I would stop my silly swinging, and go upto those parellal bars and just watch her, in a manner that would now be considered ogling. I was fascinated with the way she did her routine, right from firming up her trackpants which had a kind of a sling that went round the arch of her feet so that the pants did not gather up around her shins when she did her routine, onto the parellal bars, then onto the non-parellal bars at the far end which I till then thought were extra football and hockey goal posts, because I hadnt seen anyone else use them . She would, kind of, rotate herself on those bars, and the she would jump down, and then do perfect splits. She would arch her back and bring one leg of hers from behind onto the top of her head, the foot looking like a scorpion sting behind her, all the while balancing herself on her other leg. Then she would do side cartwheels (which she taught me later) and front cartwheels (which she wanted to teach but I threatened to run off 😊)

And all the while, she would talk to me, barely panting, and that panting too, only towards the end of her routine. And she would talk on varied stuff, sometimes fitness, sometimes trees, sometimes about Bangalore. She would travel with us in the Bangalore party and I dont really remember much of her thereafter but I do know that she went off to do something at the Brockwood park school, I suppose. She did come back once when we were in our 9th or 10th std, with a guy called George, I did go and say Hi but ...that was about it :))

Years later, when TN Seshan became the Chief Election Commissioner, is when I remembered her again and I did wonder if Suprabha was his daughter. No google then, to find out. But google her now, and she runs some self sustaining farming or something along those lines, somewhere in Kerala.

But...she deserved not to be all that. She deserved to be a gymnast ..

And one convo with her, I will always remember. There was this swimming gala that year and our Tara C T was swimming away with all the awards in all categories, right under the seniors' noses (before the bees made a mess of it all and attacked us). When I met Suprabha next during her rotations and revolutions, I was gloating to her about how my benchmate (CT sat next to me in class, before she changed sections later) had won the

swimming competitions. She said "Ya I know. She is very good. That's why she should not have participated in all categories. Very wrong". Didn't make sense, then. Thinking back now, however good she was in her gymnastics, with that thought process, she may never have ...won. Ever. In a way we narrowly understand winning.

Meeting Suprabha Seshan (later a renowned conservationist) on the playground swings, watching her gymnastics, and a remembered conversation about what it means to "win."

ENTRY 38 OF 42

Leela Akka Turns Ninety-Four

B R Venkatesh / Shabari Padaki · 3 October 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

B R Venkatesh Leela akka's 94th birthday today .

Kartik Kalyanram A great teacher

Shabari Padaki How nice!!! Such a nice and thoughtful gesture !

Happy 94th B'day dearest Leila akka! My first house mother

Krishnamurthy Happy Birthday Leela akka .we are very happy to see your birthday video. Sridevi & Krishnamurthy

Dechu Kupanda That was such a sweet moment captured. Lovely. Very sweet of you BR.

Manisha Arora Heartwarming to see this. Thank you for this sweet and thoughtful gesture 🙏🍰🎁

An alumnus honoring former house mother "Leela akka" on her 94th birthday with a cake and video; a photo-share with genuine tribute replies. (Recurr as ongoing devotion at lines 3679–3731.)

ENTRY 39 OF 42

A Harmonious Marriage

Amoolya Singh · 1 February 2026 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Condolences to Radhika Akka, Sunanda and Maya. May Hans sir rest in peace. Many fond memories of having dinner with them when Chris and I visited the valley as newlyweds and later again with kids. They modeled for us what a harmonious intercultural marriage could look like over the decades. 🙏

The one tribute worth lifting from the Hans Herzberger condolence pile-on: dining with Hans and Radhika Akka as newlyweds and later with kids, a model of harmonious intercultural marriage.

Hi Swaroopa

Multiple (Sameer Chopra, Mitali Chopra, Sajith Ansar, Shabari Padaki, wanderer) · 12 September 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Sameer Chopra Hi Swaroopa. Please give my regards/love to your parents (this is Sameer Chopra) Not to get senti 😊 but JP Sir has had more of an impact/influence on me than he realizes. Both in the formative years (I was in RV from 4th-12th; ISC 90) with English and later playing on the cricket team together (and interactions in general) — he was amongst the most popular teachers we had — and I think of him very fondly 😊

Kezia Swaroopa Hallo Sameer. Your JP sir saw your response and remembered you winning the High jump championship in Selam (tamilnadu). He also remembered Mitali's athletic skills. 😊
I will definitely show him your message. 😊

Sajith Ansar Hi swaroopa wonderful to see his pic. What a memory he has. I remember the Salem trip too. Pls say a big hi from my side. Sajith here. One year junior to sameer. Cricket, folk dance and a wonderful trek to the Himalayas all have JP sir as a central figure in our memories.

Mitali Chopra Swaroopa - JP sir was one of my fav teachers too. I also have fond memories of going caroling with him around campus at Christmas (I couldn't hold a tune to save my life but that didn't stop him from including me in the group 🎅)

Dechu Kuppanda Everyone loves JP sir and Kamala akka.

Shabari Padaki And Hello Hello there little junior girl with the two long plaits 😊
(Shabari Padaki here, ICSE '87)

Hi Swaroopa

Big hello to Kamala akka. Was terrific to see JP here at the recent B'lore reunion. SHARP memory, gosh, remembered us all in a second! Both of them were an integral part of our RV days and campus ways.

This same thread also contains the origami/Dr Parchure "small world" story already published on the site as the pick "What a Small World"; it is not repeated here.

Heartfelt tributes to JP sir and Kamala akka when his daughter joins the group; extract only the substantive lines, not the "hi Swaroopa" filler.

ENTRY 41 OF 42

An Ideal of Childhood

Kartik Kalyanram · 11 October 2025 · RVS Alumni WhatsApp

Kartik Kalyanram 5 cm rain last night. The streams have begun to flow. These photos are from near the base of Rishi Konda. Sight of children frolicking, without a care- an ideal of childhood

Shankar S.V Lovely Karthik

Anil 👍🙏

Prasanna M Nlr Bathing very similarly under 1st Bridge .

B R Venkatesh Awesome

Shabari Padaki Karthik, lovely!

A brief but evocative caption on children frolicking in newly flowing monsoon streams near Rishi Konda, "an ideal of childhood."

ENTRY 42 OF 42

A Creative Artist

Harshad Parekh · 22 August 2025 · private record (WhatsApp export; group unspecified)

I had good contact with Sivarajan in Rishi Valley for many years. We met on a road accidentally, between the dining hall and the old guest house, many times, and we talked about music and art for a long time while standing on the road.

He was a good singer, sitar player and a painter. But he never sang or played the sitar for anyone. Nor did he show his paintings to anyone.

Once I took him up on the meditation hill above the Asthachal hill, my favourite place. I requested him to sing for me. He was in a good mood. He sang a ghazal, "Lagata Nahi Hai Dil Mera," a ghazal attributed to the last Mughal king, Bahadur Shah Zafar. He sang well.

He was very shy of people and suspicious too, with some strange superstitions. He played the sitar in his room, but if he came to know that someone was outside his room listening to the sitar, he would immediately stop it.

If he were smart, he could have earned lots of money by his talents. But he remained isolated in his inner world, which was not happy.

He was a creative artist. He loved little children. But he did not like to talk with adults.

He had lived in Shantiniketan for many years before he joined Rishi Valley School in the late 1980s.

Kept here for the owner's private reference only, per instruction, as it was cut from public publication at final review.

A portrait of Sivarajan, a shy and reclusive music teacher who sang, played sitar, and painted only in private. Made the final picks.json shortlist as "A Creative Artist" but was cut at final review: unkind-reading portrait of a named teacher. Not seeded to the site under any byline.
